A Brief Commentary On Zechariah

HARRY BULTEMA

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by

Harry Bultema

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Translator's Foreword

Few are the commentaries on the fourteen chapters penned by the little-known prophet Zechariah, God's post-exilic messenger. But his message is still timely, as Calvin observed when he wrote a detailed commentary of over four hundred pages - one of the longest written on the minor prophets.

Wherever possible, the English translation follows faithfully the Dutch original. In the process of resolving several stylistic problems, I received helpful suggestions from Timothy F. Conklin, Executive Director of Grace Publications, Inc. Sometimes I paraphrased concepts and phrases, sometimes I broke larger sections down into two smaller paragraphs.

Poetic citations from Scripture have been set off as a block quotation. Biblical references have been added here and there; Bible books are abbreviated when placed between parentheses, but are written out in the text.

For the sake of the reader, a table of contents has been supplied.

Among the English translations, I consider the NKJV and RSV to do the most justice to the Dutch translation. Bultema followed the Dutch Estates translation, completed circa 1619 at the close of the international Synod of Dordt; occasionally Bultema cites marginal notes supplied by the Dutch Estates translators.

Among the more than seventy New Testament quotations from Zechariah, students of the Bible usually remember two cherished verses: Zechariah 4:6, "Not by might, nor by power, but my Spirit, saith the Lord of hosts." Hereby the prophet reaffirms his trust in God, not earthly powers, for the completion of the temple. Bultema's warning not to interpret this phrase as a vindication of spiritual laziness is, certainly, to the point. The second is Zechariah 9:9, the beautiful announcement about the triumphant and victorious king to come on a foal of an ass, frequently read on Palm Sunday, in connection with Matthew's citation (Mt. 21:5).

Living circa 1920, Bultema did not witness the founding of the state of Israel in 1947/48. But he was sensitive to the prophet's vision of future significance. He would feel comfortable, I believe, with the expression of another commentator who replied to those ignoring the dark future of our own century:

> [a] healthy, fully scriptural presentation of the course of the present age, satanic opposition to God's redemptive program, spiritual wickedness in heavenly places, the Second Coming, the kingdom of righteousness and peace could serve as a corrective ..... Zechariah is one prophet that should be studied in this connection (W. Lasor, et alii, *Old Testament Survey* [Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1982], p. 499).

Ralph Vunderink, Ph.D.

Findlay, Ohio

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PREFACE

This short and simple explanation of Zechariah originated in the friendly request made of me by a Berean society. They said they would love to possess a short "outline" of this prophecy, which they studied during their meetings. I sat down to accede to this request, and, behold, what I offer here is the result. May these and all Bereans consider this booklet useful in the investigation of God's precious Word!

H. BULTEMA

Muskegon, MI

circa 1920

INTRODUCTION

The Time of Zechariah's Ministry

"I saw by night" - that's how the prophet announced his visions during the night and, by the way, also pointed to the chronological circumstances of his ministry. When Cyrus the Great, king of Persia, had broken Babylon's power, it seemed that after seventy years of captivity the sun of Israel's salvation would at last dawn, for the Lord had softened the heart of this conqueror so that he would permit the Jews to return to their own country. Thus, the exiles were allowed to remove their harps from the willows and to move back to the sacred soil of their fathers. At first, there was great joy and a high expectation of golden times which were to start presently, so they believed. It was, to them, like a sweet dream going far beyond reality (cf. Ps. 126:1).

Suddenly, the night returned to Israel. For hardly had they commenced to build the city and the temple before the Samaritans offered to help the Israelites build in order to worship with them. The people grasped that they could not accept that request at any cost, because acceptance would be no less than a betrayal of Yahweh, the God of the fathers; thus, they refused the Samaritan offer. That refusal, understandably, caused hard feelings and resulted in a pack of wicked lies and slander against Israel at the Persian court. Apparently Israel had not counted on such resistance. Their courage of faith was no match against the schemes, and the returned exiles became discouraged and weak. The future of hope had not yet come; many were their foes; the Lord seemed to be far away; and everything was seemingly against them. In these dark days of resistance and disappointment the prophet Zechariah, the younger contemporary of Haggai, appeared as a bright-shining light. Not only prophecy as a whole, but also each true prophet in particular, is always a light shining in a dark place.

Zechariah's Personality

Scripture mentions more than thirty persons with the name of Zechariah. Signifying "the Lord remembers" (His covenant), that name was a very precious name among the Israelites. No fewer than three prophets were so named. The first was the son of the priest Jehoiada, upon whom came the Spirit of God; he severely reprimanded his step-brother, King Joash, on account of his having "forsaken the Lord," a deed for which he was stoned (to death) in the court of the house of the Lord (2 Chron. 24:20-23). The Savior names this person the last martyr (Matt. 23:35), not in the order of time but according to the sequence of the Hebrew Bible. The second prophet by that name was a contemporary and teacher of King Uzziah. The Bible narrates about this prophet that he had "understanding in the visions of God" (2 Chron. 26:5) or in another translation, "instructed [the king] in the fear of God." The third prophet is the author of the prophecy according to Zechariah.

Like Ezekiel and Jeremiah, he was a descendant of a priestly family (Ezra 5:1; Neh. 12:4, 12, 16). On this basis, perhaps, we can explain his love for the temple and the temple service. In all probability he was still a young man who deeply mourned over the ruined state of the city and the temple and the general misery of his people (Zech. 1:4). From the many questions which he posed to the angelic interpreter (the *angelus*

interpres in Jerome's Latin translation), we may safely deduce that he was of a humble character, was not ashamed to confess his ignorance, and that he thirsted after salvation in order to comfort his depressed people, having himself been comforted. We prefer to picture him as a man gifted with a rich imagination and a quick mind. Eminently, he possessed the gift to steer his people away from their present misery and to make them see the coming glory of Jerusalem.

The Purpose of Zechariah's Ministry

The prophet appeared among his people with a twofold purpose. The more immediate purpose was to give his discouraged fellow Hebrews a new heart so that they would courageously continue to build the city and the temple in spite of every opposition. Ezra narrated that this goal had been reached: "Then the prophets, Haggai the prophet, and Zechariah the son of Iddo, prophesied unto the Jews that were in Judah and Jerusalem in the name of the God of Israel, even unto them. Then rose up Zerubbabal the son of Shealtiel, and Jeshua the son of Jozadak, and began to build the house of God which is at Jerusalem; **and the prophets of God with them were helping them**" (Ezra 5:1-2). The bold-faced words show that our prophet received the honor of building the temple. He was, with his comforting promise, "the Spirit in the wheels." Ezra 6:14 also mentions him and Haggai: "So the elders of the Jews built, and they prospered through the prophesying of Haggai the prophet and Zechariah the son of Iddo. And they built and finished it .....”

The more distant goal of the prophet was to show Israel how they who were not God's people (*Lo-ammi*) could once again become His people (*Ammi*), that is, the people of the Lord. Through the mouth of Hosea the Lord had as early as two centuries ago said to Israel: "You are not my people" (Hos. 1:9). In the prophecy of Daniel, Israel is always considered *Lo-ammi*. The covenantal relationship on the Lord's side had never been broken, it is true, but on her part Israel, Yahweh's wife, did in fact break the covenant through her harlotry. Zechariah, too, views his people as not quite God's people. Hence, he does not use the covenantal name of the Lord but uses continuously His martial name; even in the short introduction of the first six verses he employs the name "Lord of hosts" or "Lord Almighty" or "Yahweh Sabaoth" five times. But now the more distant main goal of his prophecy is to show how in the end of days "Not my people" (*Lo-ammi*) will once more become "My people" (*Ammi*). Rightly has he been called the "prophet of restoration." In this brief commentary we shall have opportunity to show how time and time again the prophet comes back to this point.

The Division of Zechariah's Prophecy

This prophecy is divided perhaps more simply than any other. His work can fittingly be divided into two very different parts. The first part consists of a short introduction, stated in the first six verses, and eight visions in the night (chs. 1-6). The second part, covering chapters. 7-14, is subdivided into three closely related parts, each of which starts with the phrase "the burden of the word of the Lord." The first subdivision is located in chapters 7 and 8; the second in chapters 9-11; and the third in chapters 12-14. The tone and the style, as well as the entire manner of representing in the second main division, differ considerably from the first six chapters; thus, mainly on that account, many scholars are of the opinion that the second division is a separate prophecy, penned by

one other than Zechariah. But unjustly so! For the big difference in vocabulary and style can be sufficiently explained from the form and the goal of God's revelation. In all diversity there is, for the observant reader, a very beautiful unity and harmony.

Unique Features of Zechariah's Prophecy

Every book of the Bible has its own unique properties through which it is, more or less, distinguished from others; this prophecy is no exception. As for the form of this prophecy, it is peculiar that almost half of the prophetic instructions consist of visions seen during the night. Zechariah saw, perhaps in a single night, no fewer than eight visions, each different though similar in meaning. The higher critics have a tendency to regard all such visions as experiences of the rich soul-life of the prophet as inwardly lived, and therefore merely psychical experiences. For us, however, it is as solid as a rock that herein the Lord revealed essentially His divine will. For should these visions be merely the fruit of a rich imagination, then the prophet himself would have known the meaning of these visions.

But notice, as a second formal characteristic of his instruction, he often does not understand these visions himself. Again and again he asks for an explanation, and the Lord gave him an angel from heaven who granted him the desired light. This unique feature is our example to ask for light as he did, and his questions furthermore facilitate the explanation.

A third uniqueness, mainly from a formal viewpoint, is that, in his instruction concerning the things of the future, the prophet always chooses as his point of departure his own time and the particular circumstances of his people. This applies to all general predictions, but especially to his, and in order to understand correctly this prophecy we must keep this in mind.

But as certainly as he forever takes his point of departure in the distressful period of his time, as certainly is it that the goal of his prophecy is never limited to his own time or to the days of the Maccabees shortly thereafter. He looks across the centuries toward the return of the Lord with all His saints in order to deliver His presently groaning people from all their anxiety. The future of the Lord, and with it Israel's restoration, these are the two main features of his prophecy.

In comparison, Zechariah mentions both these features more frequently than any other (Old Testament) prophet. This is so important for him because, as a post-exilic prophet, he could not have meant Israel's return from Babylon and restoration, for that was already a *fait accompli*. No, we find the Christ in nearly every chapter. In chapter 1 the prophet sees Him as the Angel of the Lord; in the second as the One who aims to dwell in the midst of Israel; in the third as the only High Priest, the "Branch" and the foundation stone "with seven eyes;" in the fourth as the corner-stone; in the sixth as the Priest and King seated on the throne, as the Man whose name is the Branch and the real temple builder; in the eighth as Israel's King, worshipped by the nations in Jerusalem; in the ninth as the Prince of peace, reigning from "sea to sea" and from the "River to the ends of the earth;" in the tenth as the great Shepherd, clearing a way for his returning people; in the eleventh as the rejected Shepherd, sold for thirty pieces of silver; in the twelfth as the returning Messiah bemourned by those who pierced Him; in the thirteenth as the Shepherd struck by the sword of vengeance; and in the concluding

chapter, at last, as One reigning as King over the entire earth. Christ, as one can see, is the golden thread running through this prophecy, and we may also add, the key. Whoever does not see Him here cannot possibly do justice to this prophecy.

DIVISION ONE

CHAPTERS 1 – 6

The Call to Repentance (1:1-6)

1. In the eighth month, in the second year of Darius, came the word of the Lord unto Zechariah, the son of Berechiah, the son of Iddo the prophet, saying, 2. The Lord hath been sore displeased with your fathers. 3. Therefore say thou unto them, Thus saith the Lord of hosts; Turn ye unto me, saith the Lord of hosts, and I will turn unto you, saith the Lord of hosts. 4. Be ye not as your fathers, unto whom the former prophets have cried, saying, Thus saith the Lord of hosts; Turn ye now from your evil ways, and from your evildoings; but they did not hear, nor hearken unto me, saith the Lord. 5.Your fathers, where are they? and the prophets, do they live for ever? 6. But my words and my statutes, which I commanded my servants the prophets, did they not take hold of your fathers? and they returned and said, Like as the Lord of hosts thought to do unto us, according to our ways, and according to our doings, so bath he dealt with us.

Verses 1-6 constitute the introduction to the entire book. Verse 1 points to the time in which Zechariah, the son of Berachiah, commenced his prophetic ministry. His contemporary Haggai, who was a fellow prophet, had given his four short addresses two months earlier. At Ezra 5:1; 6:14, however, our prophet is represented as Haggai's co-laborer. Moreover, he is named the son of Iddo. In the biblical genealogies it happens more than once that a person is represented as the son of his grandfather or ancestor. To give an example, in 1 Chron. 4:1 Hur is still named the "son of Judah" even after five generations. That the prophet was a priest and even the head of a priestly generation is evident from Nehemiah 12:4, 16, as well as from frequent priestly representations which we encounter in his prophecies.

The purpose of this introduction is to arouse the people to a genuine repentance. This the prophet does in a very beautiful manner. Verse 2 urges the people to commemorate God's wrath. Israel was not allowed to forget its past, for its sin, guilt, and punishment contained the richest learning experiences for the present and the future. God's wrath against the "fathers" refers to the seventy years of captivity, and God wanted His people to use this as a warning, or even more appropriately, as a deterrent example for their posterity. As fiercely as He hated the sins of the past, He would punish His people again, lest they forget. For matters were such that the people had returned to Jerusalem from exile in Babylon but had not returned in their heart to the God of their fathers. Their earlier history also teaches us that people are able to leave Egypt without entering Canaan.

It is remarkable that the postexilic prophets so frequently used the name "Lord of hosts." In chapters 7 and 8 the name is used not fewer than seventeen times and in this brief introduction five times. This must be explained on the basis of the fact that God had not yet completely accepted Israel again as His people (His Ammi) but still considered them in a certain sense as strangers and enemies (Lo-ammi) on account of their deviant behavior. Therefore, He uses this military name which declares Him to be the Leader of the heavenly hosts. Not eagerly, however, does God place Himself as a wrestler against His people; on the contrary, He is rather much more willing to forgive and be rich in

mercy, as is witnessed at verse 3. Thus, is it not safely deduced that He will always be ready to accept repentant sinners with open arms?

The old paths of the fathers are often not good at all. This is clear from verse 4. It must have demanded a certain measure of courage for the youthful prophet to exclaim to the people who often boasted of the good old days, "Be not like your fathers!" Their fathers had sinned greatly and in many regards, but the Lord points out that their real sin, the culmination of their unrighteousness, consisted in refusing to accept the words of the prophets. After all, the prophets were ambassadors of the Lord and had interpreted His will in the ears of the people. By rejecting the word of these men of God they had in fact rejected the Lord Himself. This sin had yielded bitter fruits. The sad question, "Your fathers, where are they?" raised at verse 5 must point to it.

Alas, they had been driven from the land of their God given inheritance and had died in their sins in a strange country. Oh, that Israel would heed that warning today! For death destroys everything, including the prophets, who also went the way of all flesh. These divine gifts do not last forever. Let Israel listen to their voices while they can yet be heard! All flesh, even the flesh of the prophets, is like grass that quickly withers. But the word of the Lord proclaimed by the prophets continues to eternity.

Verse 6 is a contrast to the preceding section. The fathers and the prophets were no longer there but the once rejected words of the prophets were still very powerful for they had literally been fulfilled. Is this not remarkable? The Lord used the literal fulfillment of the word of prophecy as a means of coercing His people to repent. He did not wish to have it considered merely as a leading principle of scriptural interpretation but also as a great lesson of salvation history. It is, moreover, a principle that recommends itself to the conscience of the people, for according to the last part of verse 6, those returning from exile were to themselves a testimony that the Lord had literally fulfilled all His threats to them. This humble confession was a mirror for Zechariah's contemporaries, but no less for us too as we explain this prophecy and all God's words.

The First Vision: The Rider Among The Myrtle Trees (1:7-17)

7. Upon the four and twentieth day of the eleventh month, which is the month of Sebat, in the second year of Darius, came the word of the Lord unto Zechariah, the son of Berechiah, the son of Iddo the prophet, saying, 8. I saw by night, and behold a man riding upon a red horse, and he stood among the myrtle trees that were in the bottom; and behind him were there red horses, speckled, and white. 9. Then said I, O my lord, what are these? And the angel that talked with me said unto me, I will show thee what these be. 10. And the man that stood among the myrtle trees answered and said, These are they whom the Lord hath sent to walk to and fro through the earth. 11. And they answered the angel of the Lord that stood among the myrtle trees, and said, We have waked to and fro through the earth, and, behold, all the earth sitteth still, and is at rest. 12. Then the angel of the Lord answered and said, O Lord of hosts, how long wilt thou not have mercy on Jerusalem and on the cities of Judah, against which thou hast had indignation these threescore and ten years? 13. And the Lord answered the angel that

talked with me with good words and comfortable words. 14. So the angel that communed with me said unto me, Cry thou, saying, Thus sayeth the Lord of hosts; I am jealous for Jerusalem and for Zion with a great jealousy. 15. And I am very sore displeased with the heathen that are at ease: for I was but a little displeased, and they helped forward the affliction. 16. Therefore thus saith the Lord; I am returned to Jerusalem with mercies: my house shall be built in it, saith the Lord of hosts, and a line shall be stretched forth upon Jerusalem. 17. Cry yet, saying, Thus saith the Lord of hosts; My cities through prosperity shall yet be spread abroad; and the Lord shall yet comfort Zion, and shall yet choose Jerusalem.

The prophet commences a series of visions given at night. Eishhorn and others are of the opinion that the prophet saw each of these visions in a single night. For psychological reasons, however, we need not consider this very likely. As for the form and the reception of these visions, please see the introduction. The light of this prophecy shines in the night, even for us today. This entire dispensation is a night of unbelief and superstition, of ignorance and error, of pity and distress. And in this black night shines the word of the prophets through which we are told that we do well to pay attention. Prophecy is no darkness, as we often hear said, but light banning the darkness. We should keep this in mind if we want to understand these visions correctly.

The seer sees first of all a man, a rider on a red horse. This is a simple name often given to the Son of God in the Old Testament, especially in Ezekiel and Daniel. In verse 11 he is called the angel of the Lord, a name used continually for the pre-incarnate Christ. The color red is generally used to designate His own blood or the blood of His foes, thus symbolizing grace and judgment. Just as these two ideas were connected with the cross so we can reasonably join them here also, for this vision points not to the judgments concerning Israel's foes but to mercy for Israel itself.

The rider was standing in a valley surrounded by myrtle trees. Myrtle trees, like believers, grow best in a deep place. The Scripture speaks of myrtle trees four times, each of which is related to restoration following judgment; in Nehemiah 8:15; Isaiah 41:19; 55:13; and here. The myrtle trees, it is true, were in a "bottom" or hollow, for complete restoration was still a long way off.

Behind the angel were red, sorrel, and white horses. Let us also think of their riders. Here and elsewhere these are often a symbol of the willing and powerful servants of God's justice (see Rev. 6 and 9). The prophet does not comprehend what these riders symbolize. Thus he asks, ""My lord, what are these?"' Herein is he our example. When we do not understand God's Word, then we must ask Him for light and for a proper understanding of divine matters (Jas. 1:5-6).

The Lord granted the prophet an angel as his interpreter. "He spoke in me." That is how the original puts it time and time again concerning this interpreting angel (Latin *angelus interpres),* thereby indicating that he whispered everything clearly in his ear. The first rider answers Him that the three riders behind him have been sent by the Lord in order to investigate the entire world. At the same time the riders are introduced as those who have fulfilled their task and so inform their leader. Their report is, "We have walked to and fro throughout the earth, and behold, all the earth is resting quietly." The Angel of the Lord, who then prays in their behalf, exclaims, "O Lord of hosts, how long will You

not have mercy on Jerusalem and on the cities of Judah, against which You were angry these seventy years?"

The report concerning the quietness of the entire earth was no sign of gladness for this angel or cause for praise and thanksgiving, but a supplication and entreatment. This was very unwelcome news to Him because the quietness of the kingdoms of the world was founded on Israel's deep humility, scattering, and subservience. The nations of the earth ruled over God's first-born Son under the nations. The angel knows, according to the word of Haggai, the throne of the kingdoms must be turned around and the solid base of the kingdoms of the must be destroyed at the time of and as a sign of Israel's deliverance. According to the word of the same man of God, it would not take long before the Lord would cause heaven and earth to shake and all the to tremble. Now he is to hear that all was still peaceful and quiet. Seen in this light, we will comprehend His supplication on behalf of Israel's deliverance. His plea was not in vain, for he received "good and comforting words."

In his interpretation the angel explains at verse 14 what these words of comfort are. They contain the following thoughts:

(1) the nations may enjoy the lazy rest of Israel's subservience, but not so the Lord, for He is burning and glowing with zealous love for Jerusalem and Zion.

(2) In contrast, He is burning with wrath against the nations of the earth at rest which do not see that world rule belongs to Israel. In comparison with His wrath against the kingdoms of this world, the Lord was only a wee bit angry with Israel.

(3) The Lord employed the kingdoms of this world as a bully in order to whip His stiff-necked people gone astray, but they "helped, but with evil intent." That is, they had beaten Israel more than the Lord ever intended for them to do. In their anti-Semitic anger they not only made Israel subservient, but also tormented her in a most atrocious manner.

(4) As a sign of His continued covenantal faithfulness and ardent love for Israel He had already returned to Jerusalem in order to show His mercies. The plural "mercies" points to the very big and frequent proofs of His favor.

(5) His house, the temple, will be rebuilt in Jerusalem. This will be a sign that He is willing to again have communion with His people and that Jerusalem will once again become an enlarged city requiring, as a result, a measuring line.

(6) In the entire yet devastated land the destroyed cities will be rebuilt and be enlarged on account of all this goodness. In short, Israel will again become a nation flourishing in every respect. The basis of all this is not in Israel but in the free election by the Lord. He "will again choose Jerusalem." Glorious and brilliant, indeed, are the virtues of the Lord as He again receives Israel.

In order that we understand this vision during the night correctly and, strictly speaking all the others, we must notice that on the one hand the point of departure has here been chosen in the days of the exile, but that the destination reaches unto the end of the "times of the " on the other; a moment that coincides with the beginning of Israel's complete restoration. It is impossible that all interpreters who remain caught up in the days of the exile can do justice to this and other night visions. "This consolatory promise

embraces the whole of the future of the kingdom of God" (Keil & Delitz, *Minor Prophets: Zechariah* [Eerdmans, rep. 1978], p. 237).

The Second Vision: The Four Horns (1:18-21)

18. Then lifted I up mine eyes, and saw, and behold four horns. 19. And I said unto the angel that talked with me, What be these? And he answered me, These are the horns which have scattered Judah, Israel, and Jerusalem. 20. And the Lord showed me four carpenters. 21. Then said I, What come these to do? And he spake, saying, These are the horns which have scattered Judah, so that no man did lift up his head: but these are come to fray them, to cast out the horns of the Gentiles, which lifted up their horn over the land of Judah to scatter it.

The second vision is connected with the first, especially with verse 15. The prophet saw four horns. These are always the symbol of power in Scripture. The horns of the altar represent the power of grace, but otherwise they usually occur as the symbol of the power of judgment. The ox has a crushing weapon in its horns, and thus the butting with horns became a symbol of war while the horns themselves symbolize an overwhelming and destructive power. Think of these horns as horns of iron, because there is a mention of "craftsmen," literally, metal workers.

The prophet does not comprehend this vision either; therefore, he again asks the angel for the meaning. The angels, by the way, are also interpreters of Scripture and are always willing to explain, thus the proper meaning is instantly given to him and to us. The horns are the powers which destroyed and scattered Judah and Jerusalem. We need not think here of the oppressive nations of those days, for the Samaritans and Arabs did not scatter Judah. We should think here in general of world powers designated by the four wind-regions of heaven. Should one insist that we must think of four kingdoms, then one can very fittingly think of four great world kingdoms; Assyria and Babylonia, Media and Persia, Greece and Macedonia, Rome and Germany. All these world kingdoms have been anti-Semitic and often oppressed Israel, even to the point of death.

This vision consists of two parts. The Lord showed Zechariah four smiths. Once again the prophet did not comprehend what it meant and asked the angel for clarification, which was granted him immediately. The four smiths have been sent by God in order to break apart the butting horns. In such a manner God will reveal (v. 15) His great wrath against the horns of the smith, who destroyed His people. Those who view these visions exclusively as the days of Judah's return and rebuilding think of these four smiths in terms of Darius Hystaspes, Mordecai, Nehemiah, and Matthathias because these four highly favored the Jews. In any case, they think of four great benefactors of Israel. But such an interpretation utterly misjudges the character of prophecy, which as a rule does choose its point of departure in the circumstances of that time, but whose point of destination always rests in the completion and perfect deliverance. That's the focus of this vision as well, for Israel's contemporary benefactors were not together able to crush the world powers.

Should one further ask who or what these smiths represent, we cannot give an easy answer. We are not told the answer by the heavenly interpreter and therefore it is obviously not a question of the utmost importance. We could fittingly think, along with some interpreters, of the four well-known judgments of the Lord, which are so frequently mentioned in the prophetic word, namely war, famine, pestilence, and earthquakes. Equipped with sledge hammers, like sturdy smiths they will break to pieces the Gentile kingdoms. Clearly, nowadays the smiths have already commenced their work. Awake, oh Christian, for the Lord is doing great things and will soon do even greater things. "The comforting prediction of this vision is not limited to those who disperse the kingdom of God in that period in the figure of the nation of Israel but extends to the kingdom of God and His foes to the end of times" (Dachsel).

The Third Vision: The Man With The Measuring Line (Chapter 2)

1. I lifted up mine eyes again, and looked, and behold a man with a measuring line in his hand. 2. Then said I, Whither goest thou? And he said unto me, To measure Jerusalem,. to see what is the breadth thereof, and what is the length thereof. 3. And, behold, the angel that talked with me went forth, and another angel went out to meet him, 4. and said unto him, Run, speak to this young man, saying, Jerusalem shall be inhabited as towns without walls for the multitude of men and cattle therein: 5. For I, saith the Lord, will be unto her a wall of fire round about, and will be the glory in the midst of her.

Ho, ho, come forth, and flee from the land of the north, saith the Lord: for I have spread you abroad as the four winds of the heaven, saith the Lord. 7. Deliver thyself, O Zion, that dwellest with the daughter of Babylon. 8. For thus saith the Lord of hosts; After the glory hath he sent me unto the nations which spoiled you: for he that toucheth you, toucheth the apple of his eye. 9. For, behold, I will shake mine hand upon them, and they shall be a spoil to their servants: and ye shall know that the Lord of hosts hath sent me unto thee. 12. And the Lord shall inherit Judah his portion in the holy land, and shall choose Jerusalem again.

13. Be silent, O all flesh, before the Lord: for he is raised up out of his holy habitation.

The third vision, too, is very closely connected with the previous two and can be called their sequel. It is clearly meant as a further unfolding of the promised glory of Jerusalem mentioned at 1:16-17. The third vision consists of two parts: the vision of glorious Jerusalem (vv. 1-5) and a more detailed clarification and confirmation by the Angel.

The prophet saw a man with a measuring line in his hand. "Where are you going?" asked the seer with interest. The man answered that he was about to measure the size of Jerusalem. In chapter 1:16 it was promised that the measuring line would be spread across Jerusalem. In that chapter it was obviously meant to delimit what was to be built, but here it is to measure what was already rebuilt. It is said emphatically that the man wanted to measure with his measuring line the width and the length of rebuilt Jerusalem (not, note well, the height as that of the heavenly Jerusalem). And this was to be done while the city was still largely in ruins and lacked a wall. Under such circumstances, this vision must have been very comforting to the prophet and the nation. The man with the measuring line is none else than the Angel of the Lord, the Christ (cf. Ezek. 40:3; 41

and 42 where He is represented as One measuring the temple of the future). As Israel's King, our Lord Jesus Christ will accomplish the future salvation of the city and the people.

The interpreting angel proceeded to follow the man with the measuring line in order to investigate what he was doing and to give the prophet accordingly the needed information. Then the Angel of the Lord met the interpreting angel and gave him the following instruction for Zechariah: "Run, speak to this young man, saying: `Jerusalem shall be inhabited as towns because of the multitude of men and livestock in it!' ‘For I,' says the Lord, ‘will be a wall of fire all around her, and I will be the glory in her midst." A three-fold glory is promised to the yet youthful prophet, who undoubtedly mourned over the distressful condition of Jerusalem: (1) Jerusalem will become a great multitude; (2) Yahweh will be its protector; and (3) Yahweh will personally be in her midst with His glory.

There are mainly three interpretations of this vision. Imitating the scribes writing marginal notes, many first of all explain it in terms of the expansion and glory of the church of the new covenant. In the last sermons on this text of Rev. H. Hoekstra and J. Knap , Israel is not mentioned at all, but the text is explained as pertaining to the church. Second, the modern and critical interpreters on the whole explain it exclusively through the events of former times; frequently they refer to the "golden age" of the Maccabees. Third, the number of interpreters thinking of the promised future of Israel increases steadily. We shall list here only van Hamelsveld, Laan, Da Costa, Dachsel, Baron, Roos, Van Andel, Rossier, Gaebelein, Ironside, Kelly, Scofield, and others. That the third is our interpretation need hardly be said. It is a twisting of the Scripture when we this vision as the glory of the church, for while spiritual people could exist, spiritual animals could not. There are in the church "animal" (or even "beastly") spiritualists, but no "spiritual" animals. As for Jerusalem's future glory, consult the following passages: Isaiah 49:19; 60:19; Jer. 31:38-40; 33:7-13; Ezekiel 38-48; Psalm 132:13-14.

Although the real fulfillment of this vision points to the future and to Israel's complete restoration, it does not at all exclude a partial fulfillment of Israel in that era nor a generally spiritual application to the church in our day and age.

In verses 6-13 the prophet is granted a further explanation of this vision of which the main idea is that the Lord Himself, to the glory of His name, would bring about all this renown in the eyes of all the nations. This section consists of three addresses. In verses 6-9 the Jewish captives are called to flee quickly from the land of the north. Not merely Babylon and Asshur are meant, but as it seems to us, great Russia as well where six or seven million, that is half of the Jewish population, dwells. And then all the world powers inimical to Jewry, too. At that time this was the call of the Lord to the Jews who had not joined the others in their return, to prepare themselves to travel to Jerusalem. In verse 8 the Angel of the Lord explains that He was sent to the nations after the glory of the Lord's appearance in order to execute upon them the wrath of the Almighty because they had stripped Israel to the skin. The great sin of the nations is their anti-Semitism which has revealed itself continuously in different forms. The Lord considered Israel the apple of His eye. Even rejected Israel is still loved for the sake of the fathers. When the Lord appears in His glory as the Deliverer of His people He will reverse their roles

according to the law of retribution. The nations, which earlier humiliated Israel as slaves, will be booty or property and servants to their former slaves.

The second address is directed to Jerusalem (vv. 10-12). The city of God, at present still largely in ruins, may have good reasons for rejoicing, for the Angel of the Lord, Yahweh Himself, will dwell in her midst. This presence is neither a gift (Hutcheson) nor an incarnation (as others assert) but the personal return of Israel's King, our Lord Jesus Christ. As fruit of Christ's return to Israel the nations will flock to restored Israel and be converted to the Lord. This also is the continuous presentation of the prophets. Israel's restoration becomes the resurrection of the entire world. In a very beautiful manner this is being chanted, among other things, in Psalm 102:14-23. Not only the people and the city but the entire country (v. 12) will then be the sacred heritage and property of the Lord.

The third address is directed to "all flesh" (v. 13). After Christ has returned to earth and has been accepted by Israel, the whole earth along with all its inhabitants will kneel out of fear and awe for the King of kings and Lord of lords. Scripture more than once calls the final return of Christ to Israel an awakening. Israel as a people is at present sleeping the sleep of death, and its legitimate King, once rejected and crucified by His people, remains so quiet and withdrawn that it seems He is sleeping - thus we may call this a very fitting picture.

"The upshot of our argument is that we must seek the complete fulfillment in the yet future happy period when the fulness of the Gentiles will have arrived and all Israel will be saved (Rom. 11:25-27) and will return one day to its own homeland from a great dispersion of many centuries in order to serve the Lord in this manner and to receive His favor so that there will not remain any reason for the question: Did the Lord not promise more than He gave? Christians! Do not mistrust the promises of God and never try to disannul these for the sake of your own rashness, but rejoice in your faith and die in the faith, even if you did not obtain the complete fulfillment of the promise" (Laan).

The Fourth Vision: Joshua The High Priest (Chapter 3)

1. And he showed me Joshua the high priest standing before the angel of the Lord, and Satan standing at his right hand to resist him. 2. And the Lord said unto Satan, The Lord rebuke thee, O Satan; even the Lord that hath chosen Jerusalem rebuke thee: is not this a brand plucked out of the fire? 3. Now Joshua was clothed with filthy garments, and stood before the angel. 4. And he answered and spake unto those that stood before him, saying, Take away the filthy garments from him. And unto him he said, Behold, I have caused thine iniquity to pass from thee, and I will clothe thee with change of raiment. 5. And I said, Let them set a fair mitre upon his head. So they set a fair mitre upon his head, and clothed him with garments. And the angel of the Lord stood by.

6. And the angel of the Lord protested unto Joshua, saying, 7. Thus saith the Lord of hosts; If thou wilt walk in my ways, and if thou wilt keep my charge, then thou shalt also judge my house, and shalt also keep my courts, and I will give thee places to walk among these that stand by. 8. Hear now, O Joshua the high priest, thou, and thy fellows

that sit before thee: for they are men wondered at: for, behold, I will bring forth my servant the Branch. 9. For behold the stone that I have laid before Joshua; upon one stone shall be seven eyes: behold, I will engrave the graving thereof, saith the Lord of hosts, and I will remove the iniquity of that land in one day. 10. In that day, saith the Lord of hosts, shall ye call every man his neighbor under the vine and under the fig tree.

Verses 1-5 constitute the first part, verses 6-10 the second part of this vision. Scripture considers Joshua and Zerubbabel not only as leaders but also as representatives of the small crowd from Judah and Benjamin which had returned to the sacred soil of their fathers. The high priest, however, adumbrates not only Israel of old but our High Priest as well. His name is the same as Jesus' name; Yaweh saves. At the beginning of this vision he adumbrates Israel, at the end the Christ.

In the preceding vision Israel was promised great glory. But what a frightening contrast was the little band of exiles! And how earthly were the people, how deeply guilty before God and how unfaithful were the priests in their ministry! At such a sad state of affairs the timid question could not be held back in the feelings of the pious: "How long can the Lord magnify, to such an extent, a thoroughly guilty people?" To this question this vision gives a conclusive answer.

The situation was, after all, very precarious. Joshua stood before the holy face of the Angel of the Lord, the Son of God, Who is too holy to behold sin. And Joshua stood there, not clean but clothed with "filthy garments" (3:3). To make things even more precarious, Satan stood at His right hand, the accusers' place of old, "to oppose him." That was the matter naturally and spiritually for the people, here represented and symbolized by this Joshua.

The Son of God, however, intervenes. He causes Satan to rail and lets him know that the Lord has chosen Jerusalem. What God chooses Satan cannot disapprove, no matter how reprehensible he considers it to be. The majestic Advocate, further, lets the foe know that Joshua, and in a symbolic sense Israel as well, is a "brand plucked from the fire." Finally, he commands the holy angels standing before His face (for we must see the entire vision as a scene of heavenly judgment) to remove Joshua's filthy garments. He also grants him the solemn promise of the high priestly change of clothes, a promise which is fulfilled immediately (v. 5), and a "clean turban," that is, the circumscription of the high priestly turban, is put on his head.

This vision, too, interpreters consider mainly in three different ways: first, the historical (German *zeitgeschichtliche),* through which people explain all of the then occurring circumstances; second, the spiritual, which views it exclusively as a picture of the justification of the sinner; and third, the prophetic, which, agreeing with the historical starting point and the deeply spiritual teaching concerning the justification of the sinner, views the accuser of the brethren and the advocate as indicative of the complete restoration of Israel. For many centuries Israel was clothed with filthy garments, hated by Satan, accused in heaven and on earth, and in the fire of God's judgments like the burning bush, always burning but never consumed. The Son of God will one day make it a pure and priestly people, its own sin and Satan notwithstanding.

Verses 6 and 7 are a practical admonition for Joshua and his fellow priests to faithfully discharge their holy office in the Lord's house. By Ezra, Nehemiah, and post-exilic

prophets we are told that at that time the holy office was in a most sad condition. In His admonition to carefully and piously observe the office, the Lord insisted upon using the grand promise of free access to the holy angels and thus to His own throne, for the angels surround His throne. This free access to and company with the holy angels serve as a proof of the complete forgiveness of Israel's guilt and purification. Restored Israel will also one day walk among the holy angels, for the ladder to heaven, beheld as early as Jacob in his dream, will have been erected with the angels of God ascending and descending.

The earlier prophets, Isaiah and Jeremiah, often represented the Messiah in the symbol of a shoot or branch. This symbol is taken over as well-known and promised to Joshua and his fellow priests. This promise, too, was meant to incite the priests to faithful service in the House of the Lord. The image of the shoot is changed in the following verse to that of a stone, which the former prophets frequently used for the Messiah. This stone does not refer to the corner stone of the then existing temple nor to the church.

The next verse shows that we must link this stone with the time of the kingdom of peace, when all Israel will invite their neighbors to rest and peace. The Stone is Christ, considered in His relationship with God and Israel. It will have seven eyes (cf. Rev. 1:4; 4:5; 5:6, where the eyes represent His omniscience and care). The act of engraving most likely points to His suffering and death, which, more than once, are mentioned along with His future glory. Israel's unrighteousness will be removed in a single day. By right this occurred on the cross, but factually its fruit will be seen at Israel's restoration. Then even the kingdom of peace will appear to be the fruit of Christ's suffering and death.

The Fifth Vision: The Golden Lampstand (Chapter 4)

1. And the angel that talked with me came again, and waked me, as a man that is wakened out of his sleep, 2. and said unto me, What seest thou? And I said, I have looked, and behold a candlestick all of gold, with a bowl upon the top of it, and his seven lamps thereon, and seven pipes to the seven lamps, which are upon the top thereof: 3 and two olive trees by it, one upon the right side of the bowl, and the other upon the left side thereof. 4. So I answered and spake to the angel that talked with me, saying, What are these, my lord? 5. Then the angel that talked with me answered and said unto me, Knowest thou not what these be? And I said, No, my lord. 6. Then he answered and spake unto me, saying, This is the word of the Lord unto Zerubbabel, saying, Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, saith the Lord of hosts. 7. Who art thou, O great mountain? before Zerubbabel thou shalt become a plain: and he shall bring forth the headstone thereof with shoutings, crying, Grace, grace unto it. 8. Moreover the word of the Lord came unto me, saying, 9. The hands of Zurabbabel have laid the foundation of this house; his hands shall also finish it; and thou shalt know that the Lord of hosts hath sent me unto you. 10. For who hath despised the day of small things? for they shall rejoice, and shall see the plummet in the hand of Zerubbabel with those seven; they are the eyes of the Lord, which run to and fro through the whole earth.

11. Then answered I, and said unto him, What are these two olive trees upon the right side of the candlestick and upon the left side thereof? 12. And I answered again, and said unto him, What be these two olive branches, which through the two golden pipes empty the golden oil out of themselves? 13. And he answered me and said, Knowest thou not what these be? And I said, No, my lord. 14. Then said he, These are the two anointed ones, that stand by the Lord of the whole earth.

Some time seems to have lapsed between the previous four visions and the fifth one, for it is said about the angel that he returned, which assumes a temporary departure, and that the prophet awakened as from a deep sleep. The prophet saw a golden lampstand and a bowl filled with oil pouring on either side through the seven pipes to the seven lamps. At the right and left were two olive trees in order to continuously provide new liquid for the bowl at the top.

Another time the prophet had to reveal his ignorance as well as his holy curiosity by asking for the proper meaning of all this. Herein he is the example for all of us. Oh, would that there were more such questions in the congregation in order to become wise in God's infallible Word! The willingness of the Lord to instruct His people with answers to questions appears time after time. The Angel said to him, "Not by might nor by power, but by my Spirit" will it happen (4:6). This phrase has often been misused by dull and passive souls. They thought it wondrously beautiful to be able to cover up their own laziness with a biblical proof-text. This phrase does not grant a passport to the lazy, but contains first of all an exhortation to Zerubbabel and Israel that at every resistance in the rebuilding of the temple they were not to seek their salvation in force of arms and military armies, nor in favor of kings, alliances, or power of money, or in any other form of the "flesh," but that they were to place their confidence in the Lord and to expect everything from Him as the genuine Master Builder of the temple. Silently and steadily, just like oil flowing through the pipes to the chandeliers, the Spirit of the Lord would complete His work.

"Who are you, O great mountain?" Thus it is further told in vivid and poetic representation that all resistance will be crushed by the Lord Himself. "When He works, who then shall turn Him?" Some interpret this as the mountains of objections in general, but it is more in accord with Biblical imagery to think here of a kingdom; either that of the Medes and the Persians, a world power in general, or the antichristian kingdom of the last days. It is clear, however, that in this vision, more so than in the preceding ones, the condition of those days influences the symbolism of this vision and as a result points, not as much as the others, to the future. We say emphatically not as much for whoever would think that this vision would not look further than to the circumstances of those days would be utterly mistaken.

Here, too, we may not linger at the history of those days, for considered properly prophecy never does that. It always looks toward the distant future and the great perfection. Therefore, we cannot merely see in Zerubbabel a god-fearing governor at that time, for he never humbled a kingdom to a valley. The Lord Jesus, here as in Haggai introduced by Zerubbabel, will one day humiliate the proud mountain of the antichrist. He shall complete the House of the Lord; the spiritual house, His congregation, but also the temple of the future, of which the prophet Ezekiel gave such an extensive description. This completion of the temple is meant when it is said that he

would produce the "headstone" (v. 7). In the preceding chapter He is represented as the cornerstone of the foundation; here He is the keystone. Among the older Hebrews it was customary to express great joy at the dedication of the temple (e.g., Ezra 3:8; 6:16). That's how it happened in the days of Ezra and Zerubbabel and in this way it will happen once again still more gloriously in the days of the great Zerubbabel. Then the Son of God will proclaim the manifold grace of the Lord over His people and will command His favor to rest upon His House.

Verses 8-14 clarify this vision a bit more. Should Israel have believed from the heart in all the promised salvation, then it could not have escaped her that the building of the temple by Zerubbabel was not at all the fulfillment of the rich promises of the Lord. That way many a pious Jew became disappointed in their heart when the complete salvation continued to be delayed and everything remained so unsightly and so insignificant; the "old men" wept with a deep sadness (cf. Ezra 3:812). Against it is the solemn warning of the Lord in verse 10. Neither the faded glory of the past nor the rising glory of the far future may ever prompt us to minimize the present day of small things.

A reason for this injunction not to despise is given; the seven eyes of the stone rejoice when they see the plumb line in the hand of Zerubbabel. This plumb line is a sign that the edifice was completed and that everything had found its perfect place.

The prophet's curiosity is not wholly satisfied. Therefore he asks further for the real significance of the two olive trees and the branches of the olive trees which were connected with a bowl and made the golden oil drain through the two gold pipes. Somewhat surprised, the angel asked him, "Do you not know what these are?" Honestly and yet humbly the prophet replied, "No, my Lord" (v. 13). Then the angel gave him a very mysterious answer, "These are the two [olive branches], who stand [in front of] the Lord of the whole earth" (v. 14, Bultema's translation). Some consider it an evasive answer. Others translate it as two "anointed with oil" and think of the prophets Haggai and Zechariah or even Zerubbabel and Joshua. It says literally, the two "sons of oil." This, obviously, points to two people anointed with oil. The definite article here reminds us of the holy oil of anointing prepared to anoint the most holy office bearers (Lev. 21:10; 1 Sam. 10:1). It is reasonable to accept that the two anointed ones are first of all meant to be Joshua and Zerubbabel, who represent the offices of High Priest and King; but it seems to us that in Jerusalem two witnesses will arise for the Lord in the days of the Great Tribulation, a prophecy mentioned at Revelation 11 which alludes to this Old Testament passage, before Israel's lampstand will radiate its light into the world.

The Sixth Vision: The Flying Scroll (5:1-4)

1. Then I turned, and lifted up mine eyes, and looked, and behold a flying roll. 2. And he said unto me, What seest thou? And I answered, I see a flying roll; the length thereof is twenty cubits, and the breadth thereof ten cubits. 3. Then said he unto me, This is the curse that goeth forth over the face of the whole earth: for every one that stealeth shall be cut off as on this side according to it; and every one that sweareth shall be cut off as on that side according to it. 4. I will bring it forth, saith the Lord of hosts, and it shall

enter into the house of the thief, and into the house of him that sweareth falsely by my name: and it shall remain in the midst of his house, and shall consume it with the timber thereof and the stones thereof.

This chapter contains not merely one but two prophetic visions; it must be conceded to those who wish to join them together, however, that they are very close in content and scope. But we cannot join them together for that reason alone, for the same can be said concerning each of the eight visions, and according to that rule we could conceive of these as a single vision during the night with one main thought.

In the sixth night vision an opened parchment scroll of mammoth measurements is shown to the spirit of the seer. On one side is written a curse against thieves and a curse against perjurers is written on the other. This vision is distinct from the preceding ones in that it does not contain so much a word of comfort for the good as it does a threatening word for the godless. And yet the people of the Lord can proclaim a joyful hallelujah, together with the psalmist of Psalm 104 at the thought that the godless will be destroyed from the midst of the people of God and from the entire creation of the Lord. Thus even this vision in the night may be called a vision "of great comfort."

We are to represent the scroll as flying through the air from the halls of justice above to the earth beneath. That it is rolled up signifies that it is to be read, for when people had read the parchment scrolls of the Law they rolled these up on a stick and put them away. The size of the scroll points to the generality of those crimes committed among the returning exiles and, further, to the magnitude of the punishment to be meted out to thieves and purjurers.

To behold this sublime vision must have been a frightening experience. The scroll's extraordinary size, its flying through the air, its being written on either side with a large and perhaps flaming script, for the prophet must have seen this vision during the night, all this must have contributed to increase the impression of the whole. The scroll had the same dimensions as the vestibule of Solomon's temple (1 Kgs. 6:3). Maybe it suggests that the written curses on the scroll are as spotlessly holy as the holy of holies in the House of the Lord which presently reemerges from its ashes.

A further explanation of this vision is given orally once again (v. 4). The curse shall "enter the house of the thief" just as the latter is accustomed to enter the house of his or her neighbor in a hidden manner. A counter retribution will be his or her part. The curse of the Lord will remain forever in the homes of the thief and the perjurer, and the undermining will remain until the woodwork and the masonry collapse and become a ruin. Sin undermines every home, as well as every state and society. Whoever does evil will receive evil. God must punish evil, let us think of that.

The flying scroll with its flaming script about curses also flew in the air for our people and time. It is also with our people a very sad situation in connection with the two tables of the law represented on this scroll. The Lord's name is not hallowed, and the neighbor's well-being is not respected. Oh, land, land, hear the Word of the Lord! The flying scroll written with the curses of the Lord flies quickly through the air, proof that the Lord's judgments will come in haste upon a godless generation.

The Seventh Vision: The Woman in An Ephah (5:5-11)

5. Then the angel that talked with me went forth, and said unto me, Lift up now thine eyes, and see what is this that goeth forth. 6. And I said, What is it? And he said, This is an ephah that goeth forth. He said moreover, This is their resemblance through all the earth. 7. And, behold, there was lifted up a talent of lead: and this is a woman that sitteth in the midst of the ephah. 8. And he said, This is wickedness. And he cast it into the midst of the ephah; and he cast the weight of lead upon the mouth thereof. 9. Then lifted I up mine eyes, and looked, and behold, there came out two women, and the wind was in their wings; for they had wings like the wings of a stork: and they lifted up the ephah between the earth and the heaven. 10. Then said I to the angel that talked with me, Whither do these bear the ephah? 11. And he said unto me, To build it a house in the land of Shinar: and it shall be established, and set there upon her own base.

At the command of the angel, the prophet once again must lift up his eyes. In order that we, too, understand aright God's Word we must not close our eyes nor watch the earth or think of earthly things, but we must raise our eyes continuously to heaven. Though the prophet looked very intently, this was another time he did not comprehend what he saw, and so again he asked for clarification. He was told that he saw an "ephah" or basket. Among the Israelites the ephah was the largest dry measure, about the size of a bushel and large enough to contain a woman small of stature in a hunched position. The angel added, "This is their resemblance," signifying outer shape. According to the angel the ephah was a symbol of commerce and industry and represents the external condition of all Israel. After the exile God's people, against God's will, became commercialistic and godless in their business dealings (v. 8). The result of such abuses were stealing and swearing falsely.

The prophet saw a woman sitting in the ephah. When Scripture mentions a woman in an unfavorable sense it usually designates false and seductive religion, a religion mixed with idolatry or immoral politics and commerce. Here as well the woman is explained by the angel as godlessness, an atrocious mixing of holy and unholy things. When we compare this woman with the woman mentioned at Rev. 17-18 we notice that the second passage sheds a surprising light on the matter.

The leaden cover which the angel had lifted for a moment that the prophet might see the woman sitting in the ephah was immediately put down again with force. The ephah was a prison for the mysterious woman. As soon as she had seen the ephah opened she had, apparently, wanted to escape but she was thrust back once again by the hand of the angel (v. 8). At the same time two other mysterious women came flying as with wings of a stork. They lifted the ephah with the woman inside from the ground and flew away. Astonished, the prophet asked once more, "Where are they taking the ephah?" (v. 10). "To build it a house in the land of Shinar," the angel replied, "and when it is prepared, they will set the ephah down there on its base" (v. 11), that is, there it will be established and put on its foundation.

That these two women who carried away the ephah with its enclosed godlessness are compared with storks suggests that just as storks always return to their dirty nest, even so the godlessness of commercialism which Israel had learned in Babylon will be brought back to this dirty nest. The land of Shinar is Babylon and it is to that region that the ephah is taken. There, according to the express explanation of the angel in verse 11, it will remain forever (cf. Rev. 17).

Even though all this is very mysterious and miraculous, the main thought of this chapter is clear enough. (1) Sinners and sin itself will wholly be eradicated from Israel, for Israel's complete restoration cannot occur except with a complete return to God. (2) In Babylon, where sin on earth originated and had most alarmingly revealed itself, sin will dwell as in a dirty nest in order that there at the end of days God's judgments would visit it. Thus the main thought is as follows: an eternal separation between and isolation of God's kingdom from the kingdom of the world!

The Eight Vision: The Four Chariots (6:1-8)

1. And I turned, and lifted up mine eyes, and looked, and, behold, there came four chariots out from between two mountains; and the mountains were mountains of brass. 2. In the first chariot were red horses; and in the second chariot black horses; 3. and in the third chariot white horses; and in the fourth chariot grizzled and bay horses. 4. Then I answered and said unto the angel that talked with me, What are these, my lord? 5. And the angel answered and said unto me, These are the four spirits of the heavens, which go forth from standing before the Lord of all the earth. 6. The black horses which are therein go forth into the north country; and the white go forth after them; and the grizzled go forth toward the south country. 7. And the bay went forth, and sought to go that they might walk to and fro through the earth: and he said, Get you hence, walk to and fro through the earth. So they walked to and fro through the earth. 8. Then cried he upon me, and spake unto me, saying, Behold, these that go toward the north country have quieted my spirit in the north country.

The first part of this chapter contains the eighth and last vision. The prophet saw four wagons or carts coming from between two mountains of bronze. We must think here of chariots, the symbol of war and judgment. The blood-red horses in front of the first chariot also point to this symbol. Likewise, the black horses are put before the second chariot as a symbol of scarcity, expensiveness, and hunger (cf. the riders in Rev. 6). The white war horses point to brilliant victories while the dappled, that is, black and white mingled together, seem to point to a mixture of misery and glory. Only the last horses, not all the horses, are introduced as being strong, that is, spirited and proudly racing toward the battle field. That the mountains are said to be of bronze does not mean that they contained copper ore, but that they were as firm as bronze and as hard as God's stern justice.

The heavenly interpreter answers the supplication for information as follows: "These are the four spirits of heaven"' (v. 5). The Hebrew word "wind" is the same as the word "spirit;" thus it is obvious that in our text the angels are meant to be obliging spirits of

divine judgment. The Lord made the winds His "messengers" and fire and flame His "ministers" (Ps. 104:4; cf. Rev. 7:1). Scripture designates the angels as the great servants of the Lord's court of justice. Even if one did not wish to think of angels but of winds, even then one must conceive of these as a means of judgment. In the prophecies clouds, winds, hail, fire, streams, plagues, hunger, and earthquakes are the pending symbols and means of the judgments of the Lord.

The four chariots were coming from between the mountains of bronze. The words "come from" and "go to" we meet with again and again in the visions of Zechariah, especially in the sixth and seventh visions, and these words always relate to judgment against godlessness. Thus, we do not share the view of some interpreters that these four chariots represent four world powers, but rather the Lord's servants of judgments. This last vision is mainly connected with the first where there as well the heavenly messengers were seated on horses of differing colors. At that time the world powers were not as yet ripe for judgment and everything was still quiet and peaceful, with the heavenly horsemen standing in the valley between the myrtle trees. In contrast, now the chariots rush down the hill and spread to all the four wind-regions of heaven.

It should not escape our attention that Scripture emphasizes the storm of judgment rages particularly in the land of the north (Russia), the land comprising half the world's population of the people of Israel and oppressing it more than did any other nation. Some are of the opinion that these chariots have been sent to gather scattered Israel from among all the nations and to bring the people back to their own homeland, but the obvious intention is that all the nations are judged by the Lord, notably those which oppressed Israel the most. The land of the north is mentioned by name. A great difficulty, however, is the expression in verse 8 "have quieted my spirit in the north country." Some think of the spirit of judgment while others take in the good sense of the Holy Spirit. The latter meaning seems to us the most likely one, for the expression the "spirit of judgment" means little and is never used in this way. We do know that following all the judgments against the nations the Lord will pour out His Spirit upon all flesh. Through these judgments the nations will learn righteousness.

The Symbolic Crowning of Joshua (6:9-15)

9. And the word of the Lord came unto me, saying, 10. Take of them of the captivity, even of Heldai, of Tobijah, and of Jedaiah, which are come from Babylon, and come thou the same day, and go into the house of Josiah the son of Zephaniah; 11. then take silver and gold, and make crowns, and set them upon the head of Joshua the son of Josedech, the high priest; 12. and speak unto him, saying, Thus speaketh the Lord of hosts, saying, Behold the man whose name is The Branch; and he shall grow up out of his place, and he shall build the temple of the Lord: 13. even he shall build the temple of the Lord; and he shall bear the glory, and shall sit and rule upon his throne; and he shall be a priest upon his throne: and the counsel of peace shall be between them both. 14. And the crowns shall be to Helem and to Tobijah, and to Jedaiah, and to Hen the son of Zephaniah, for a memorial in the temple of the Lord.

15. And they that are far off shall come and build in the temple of the Lord, and ye shall know that the Lord of hosts hath sent me unto you. And this shall come to pass, if ye will diligently obey the voice of the Lord your God.

These verses can be considered the concluding word of the night visions. Simultaneously, they constitute their culmination point, if not their key. From the three Jews mentioned by name, who had recently returned from Babylon in order to bring their presents to the completed temple, the prophet, who thus far saw only visions but now is obligated to take action, must accept gold and silver and make therefrom a crown of silver and gold to be put on the head of Joshua the high priest. The prophet no doubt enacted this symbolic event in the presence of the company of the pious in the home of a certain Josiah.

Having executed the deed, the prophet had to clarify his deed with the following words, "Behold the Man whose name is the Branch! From His place He shall branch out, And He shall build the temple of the Lord" (v. 12). The higher critics wish to understand by the name "the Branch" one of the Maccabean princes, but we should not think of anyone but our Savior, who frequently is named the Branch (Heb. *samah*) by the prophets (cf. Jer. 23:5; 33:15; Zech. 3:8). In the glorious Messianic prophecy given here are the following elements:

(1) He will come as a Man, specifically as a weak Man, as the name "Branch" suggests. Thus Isaiah calls him also a "root out of dry ground" (Isa. 53:2).

(2) Not immediately will He act with majesty and glory, for He will "shoot" from His place. This points to His humble origin.

(3) He will build the Lord's temple as it is emphatically stressed. This does not refer to the spiritual temple of His church which He at present is building through His Spirit. And neither can it be the temple dating from that time, nor the temple of Herod or of the antichrist. This temple is meant to be the same described so extensively by Ezekiel, which in the millennium will be a house of prayer for all the nations. Verse 15 points to the exiles being given a word of consolation so that even those dwelling in lands far away will come and assist in rebuilding Yahweh's temple. A beautiful type of this fact of future salvation is given in Solomon's days when Hiram, king of Tyre, supplied laborers and raw materials for the temple of the Lord.

(4) The builder of the temple will be clothed with royal majesty. This is, as seems to us, the meaning of the expression: "He shall bear the glory" (v.13). He will be King (cf. Isa. 9:6, "Prince"). This is further described in the following words, "[He] shall sit and rule on His throne" (v. 13). At present Christ is not seated on His own throne, according to his express declaration. However, He is seated on the throne of His Father.

(5) This King will be distinguished from the preceding kings of Israel because He, like Melchizedek, represents in his high priestly Person the two offices of priest and king (see also Ps. 110). Pious king Uzziah once wanted to perform the priestly work in the temple but he was thrown out of the temple and struck by the Lord with leprosy. He will be seated on His throne like a priest, and between these two offices there will be the most beautiful harmony and symmetry. How the expression "counsel of peace" has ever

been conceived of as a designation of the eternal covenant of redemption is a complete riddle. There is nothing in the text pointing to it.

After the symbolic action just described, the two crowns (the golden crown pointed to royal majesty and the silver crown to priestly splendor) had served their purpose. The prophet was to take both of them and hang them in the temple as a memorial and a temple treasure for the generations to come. Apparently, an honorable superscription had to be made to the effect that they were honored by these persons in the holy place.

A King as High Priest, One who offered Himself up for His people who were at one time His foes, and Who ascended to the throne not via the blood of His foes but through His Own blood, will one day draw all nations to Himself when seated on His Own throne as the illustrious Priest-King of Israel and all the nations. Psalm 72 will then be fulfilled literally.

DIVISION TWO

CHAPTERS 7 - 14

Fasting (Chapter 7)

1. And it came to pass in the fourth year of king Darius, that the word of the Lord came unto Zechariah in the fourth day of the ninth month, even in Chisleu; 2. when they had sent unto the house of God Sherezer and Regem-melech, and their men, to pray before the Lord, 3. and to speak unto the priests which were in the house of the Lord of hosts, and to the prophets, saying, Should I weep in the fifth month, separating myself, as I have done these so many years? 4. Then came the word of the Lord of hosts unto me, saying, 5. Speak unto all the people of the land, and to the priests, saying, When ye fasted and mourned in the fifth and seventh month, even those seventy years, did ye at all fast unto me, even to me? 6. And when ye did eat, and when ye did drink, did not ye eat for yourselves, and drink for yourselves? 7. Should ye not hear the words which the Lord hath cried by the former prophets, when Jerusalem was inhabited and in prosperity, and the cities thereof round about her, when men inhabited the south and the plain?

8. And the word of the Lord came unto Zechariah, saying, 9. Thus speaketh the Lord of hosts, saying, Execute true judgment, and show mercy and compassions every man to his brother: 10. and oppress not the widow, nor the fatherless, the stranger, nor the poor; and let none of you imagine evil against his brother in your heart. 11. But they refused to hearken, and pulled away the shoulder, and stopped their ears, that they should not hear. 12. Yea, they made their hearts as an adamant stone, lest they should hear the law, and the words which the Lord of hosts hath sent in his Spirit by the former prophets: therefore came a great wrath from the Lord of hosts. 13. Therefore it is come to pass, that as he cried, and they would not hear; so they cried, and I would not hear, saith the Lord of hosts: 14. but I scattered them with a whirlwind among all the nations whom they knew not. Thus the land was desolate after them, that no man passed through nor returned: for they laid the pleasant land desolate.

The second main division of Zechariah consists of three parts: chapters 7-8, chapters 9-11, and chapters 12-14. Part one (chapters 7-8) contains the answer which God gave all his people on account of a question raised in the name of the entire colony of returned exiles and posed by a delegation from Bethel concerning fasting. In order to comprehend this question of the people, we must know that during the frightening days of Jerusalem's siege and destruction, a good seventy years earlier, the people had instituted four days of fasting. A fast in the tenth month commemorating Nebuchadnezzar's siege of Jerusalem (Jer. 52:4-5); a fast in the fourth month to call to mind the capture of the city (Jer. 52:6); a fast in the fifth month commemorating the burning of the temple (2 Chr. 36:19); and, finally, a fast in the seventh month to commemorate the gruesome murder of Gedaliah the governor, as a result of which those left behind fled to Egypt out of fear.

The most important day of fasting, naturally, was the day on which the burning of the temple was commemorated. But now that the people saw the temple reemerged from its rubble, the question arose automatically whether they should still continue to celebrate this and similar days of fasting. It seemed there also arose quite a dispute

about it, for as a rule there is no lack of such religious extremes on either side. Thus they had decided at Bethel to send two important representatives with their train as a delegation to Jerusalem with the charge to ask the priests and the prophets concerning this matter. Due to the question of this delegation, the prophet Zechariah gave a punitive speech to all the people, which goes as far as the end of the following chapter. Let us take a closer look at this address.

In between the night visions of the first six chapters and this answer as it relates to the fast, two years had passed. Worthy to be noted is the name (up to seventeen times) with which the Lord names Himself here in this answer. He does not call Himself "Yahweh," a name which designated his covenantal relationship to Israel, but instead, the "Lord of Hosts."

It is of the utmost importance, if we wish to understand this prophecy correctly, to realize the Lord had not as yet accepted Israel again as His people but still considered and treated them as *Lo-ammi*, that is, "Not my people." For that reason He names Himself on purpose the God of the heavenly host, as if He had withdrawn Himself from Israel and gone to heaven. Consequently He directed Himself to the conscience of all the people in a fierce punishment. The delegation from Bethel did not receive a private but a public answer. That answer is simultaneously a most sharp punishment and a penitential speech. This leads us to the rightful presupposition that the keeping of days of mourning and fasting contained much that immensely displeased the Lord. They had never advanced with all their mourning and complaining and fasting as much as did the Gentile Ninevites, who by their action had spared their city. Evidently the Hebrews had mourned more over their destiny than over their sins. Fasting had apparently become a mechanical custom whereby the heart remained cold and indifferent and whereby the big majority of the people could continue to remain, rather peacefully, with the "fleshpots of Babylon."

Worse yet, the flaming eye of the Lord apparently discerned, even in the question of this delegation, the malicious principles of Pharisaism. What would it benefit the people if on certain days of the year they went there to worship with their heads hanging, covered with dust and ashes, barefooted, and clothed with a garment of mourning (Isa. 58:5), if they did not humble themselves before the face of the Lord! It was really absurd to ask to be discharged from a religious institution which was never ordered by the Lord. The days of fasting were a man-made religion; so why did they want to be released from these? The Lord deprives them of the delusion that they fasted in His honor when He asks sharply: "Did you really fast for me-for Me?" (v. 5). Correctly has it been said that here the Lord fought against Pharisaism from its beginning, because it would bring even more misery to the people than did the idolatry of the fathers.

In order that they would feel their fasting possessed absolutely no religious value, the Lord draws a comparison between their days of fasting and the feast days. When they celebrated their festivals, it was not done in honor of His name; no more than was their fasting in His honor. This was so Israel would not think the Lord announced here brand-new principles, for during times of prosperity before the Babylonian exile the former prophets spoke similarly as well (v. 7). There is no doubt here an allusion to the Lord's punitive speech concerning the fast mentioned in Isaiah 58 (cf. Isa. 58 with Zech. 7, esp. v. 5).

In verses 8-10 the Hebrews are reminded of what the Lord desired of Israel, then as well as now. Verses 11-12 point to Israel's disobedience and verses 13-14 to the enormous punishment for their disobedience. Oh, that Israel would take this warning to heart!

Jerusalem's Glory (Chapter 8)

1. Again the word of the Lord of hosts came to me, saying, 2. Thus saith the Lord of hosts; I was jealous for Zion with great jealousy, and I was jealous for her with great fury. 3. Thus saith the Lord; I am returned unto Zion, and will dwell in the midst of Jerusalem: and Jerusalem shall be called A city of truth; and the mountain of the Lord of hosts, The holy mountain. 4. Thus saith the Lord of hosts; There shall yet old men and old women dwell in the streets of Jerusalem, and every man with his staff in his hand for very age. 5. And the streets of the city shall be full of boys and girls playing in the streets thereof. 6. Thus saith the Lord of hosts; If it be marvelous in the eyes of the remnant of this people in these days, should it also be marvelous in mine eyes? saith the Lord of hosts. 7. Thus saith the Lord of hosts; Behold, I will save my people from the east country, and from the west country; 8. and I will bring them, and they shall dwell in the midst of Jerusalem: and they shall be my people, and I will be their God, in truth and in righteousness.

9. Thus saith the Lord of hosts; Let your hands be strong, ye that hear in these days these words by the mouth of the prophets, which were in the day that the foundation of the house of the Lord of hosts was laid, that the temple might be built. 10. For before these days there was no hire for man, nor any hire for beast; neither was there any peace to him that went out or came in because of the affliction: for I set all men every one against his neighbor. 11. But now I will not be unto the residue of this people as in the former days, saith the Lord of hosts. 12. For the seed shall be prosperous; the vine shall give her fruit, and the ground shall give her increase, and the heavens shall give their dew; and I will cause the remnant of this people to possess all these things. 13. And it shall come to pass, that as ye were a curse among the heathen, O house of Judah, and house of Israel; so will I save you, and ye shall be a blessing: fear not, but let your hands be strong.

14. For thus saith the Lord of hosts; As I thought to punish you, when your fathers provoked me to wrath, saith the Lord of hosts, and I repented not: 15. so again have I thought in these days to do well unto Jerusalem and to the house of Judah: fear ye not. 16. These are the things that ye shall do; Speak ye every man the truth to his neighbor; execute the judgment of truth and peace in your gates: 17. and let none of you imagine evil in your hearts against his neighbor; and love no false oath: for all these are things that I hate, saith the Lord.

18. And the word of the Lord of hosts came unto me, saying, 19. Thus saith the Lord of hosts; The fast of the fourth month, and the fast of the fifth, and the fast of the seventh, and the fast of the tenth, shall be to the house of Judah joy and gladness, and cheerful feasts; therefore love the truth and peace.

20. Thus saith the Lord of hosts; it shall yet come to pass, that there shall come people, and the inhabitants of many cities: 21. and the inhabitants of one city shall go to another, saying, Let us go speedily to pray before the Lord, and to seek the Lord of hosts: I will go also. 22. Yea, many people and strong nations shall come to seek the Lord of hosts in Jerusalem, and to pray before the Lord. 23. Thus saith the Lord of hosts; In those days it shall come to pass, that ten men shall take hold out of all languages of the nations, even shall take hold of the skirt of him that is a Jew, saying, We will go with you: for we have heard that God is with you.

The sharp penitential speech suddenly changes to a glorious speech of consolation. Sudden turns such as this one are often encountered in the prophets. Seldom do they deliver a long and interlocking argument, and more than once can they speak in one breath of sin and deliverance, destruction and glory. Thus here as well, according to the Word of the Lord, the prophet paints a lovely picture of happy times which one day will come to Judah and Jerusalem. In the last verse of the preceding chapter the Lord had indicated that through its own iniquity Israel itself had turned the desired land into a wasteland.

In a surprising contrast therewith, the Lord from His side now says He has continuously shown the greatest interest in Zion. He had loved Judah, Jerusalem, and the land of precious jewels with the ardor of a lover. He was zealous for His portion, and therefore His ardor was provoked in flaming wrath against those who destroyed His holy inheritance. At first, though, He did return to Zion and repeat the promise He would dwell "in the midst of Jerusalem" (v. 4). For the sake of clarity, we count the promised privileges of the Jerusalem of the future as follows:

(1) The Lord Himself will return to Jerusalem and remain present there (v. 3). This was not at that time fulfilled and neither has it been today. Though the fig tree (Israel) budded as a sign of approaching summer, Israel is still *Lo-ammi,* and the Lord has not as yet returned to Jerusalem in His full favor. Not until after Christ's return to rebuild the new temple will Jerusalem be called "The Lord is there" (Heb. *Yahweh Samma,* Ezek. 48:35).

(2) Only when the Lord will have returned in order to dwell in Jerusalem will Jerusalem be called a city of truth (cf. Isa. 1:21). In Jesus' day this city was still the city which murdered the prophets, and afterward it has still never deserved that dear name. Then it will be called the "Mountain of the Lord of Hosts" and the "Holy Mountain" (v. 3b).

(3) Great blessings will be bestowed on Israel. The city will be full of people; it will be safe, peaceful, and fertile as the fruit of divine presence and protection. In addition, the people will enjoy health and a long life (vv. 4-5).

(4) Foreseeing these glorious promises would be marvelous and unbelievable in the estimation of the returned exiles, the Lord assures it is not marvelous in His eye. With His own hand He will gather His scattered people and cause them to return to Jerusalem (vv. 6-8).

Verse 9 contains a call to the temple builders. The initial flourishing of the people, in contrast with their misery of about eighteen years earlier, should cause them to realize that "it pays" to listen to the words of the prophets, who at present urge them to build

the temple. From now on, if they would be obedient to Him the Lord would no longer walk with them contrariwise but would make them very prosperous and fertile (vv. 11-12). Verses 13-15 present a remarkable comparison between the curse of the past and the blessing of the future. We call this a remarkable comparison because it contains "volumes of teachings" for us, both for our explanation of Scripture and our expectations of the future. There is none who dares to deny that the curse of the past came literally upon Israel in all its frightening horrors. This fact is simply not denied by anyone. Israel itself does not dare deny it, for during many centuries it has experienced, indeed, felt the impact of this curse on its "body," so to speak,

Thus the Lord says "so again," in the same way as the curse came really and literally upon you, "have I purposed in these days to do good to Jerusalem and to the house of Judah" (v. 15). This comparison indicates the pure principles for the exegesis of prophecy and for the expectation of the future. Words like these, which we notice so often in the prophets, forbid us once and for all to conceive of the curses as literal events and the promised blessings as symbolic happenings. Whoever does it anyway goes counter to the infallible Word of the Lord.

Grateful for the promised blessings and in preparation for the future name of Jerusalem, City of Truth, the remnant must remain in the truth *vis-à-vis* God and their neighbor (vv. 16-17). Following these penitential and consolatory speeches, at last a glorious answer concerning fasting is given. Its message is as follows: as free men they can continue to celebrate these days; not to mourn, but to thank God with great joy. In brief, the days of fasting must be changed into days of feasting, showing thankfulness for God's beneficence. And in it all they must love truth and peace. Let us watch this divine order: never to love sweet peace at the expense of the truth, but instead, as its fruit. Every peace that rests upon a lie is a false peace, and a holy war is endlessly better than this.

The last four verses of this chapter contain a glorious promise concerning the incorporation of the Gentiles after Israel's restoration. Just as there was a curse, so there will one day be a blessing. We should interpret these words just as they are written; then they do not cause us difficulties, speaking as they do for themselves.

Judgment And Salvation (9:1-8)

1. The burden of the word of the Lord in the land of Hadrach, and Damascus shall be the rest thereof: when the eyes of man, as of all the tribes of Israel, shall be toward the Lord. 2. And Hamath also shall border thereby; Tyrus, and Zidon, through it be very wise. 3. And Tyrus did build herself a stronghold, and heaped up silver as the dust, and fine gold as the mire of the streets. 4. Behold, the Lord will cast her out, and he will smite her power in the sea; and she shall be devoured with fire.

5. Ashkelon shall see it, and fear; Gaza also shall see it, and be very sorrowful, and Ekron; for her expectation shall be ashamed; and the king shall perish from Gaza, and Ashkelon shall not be inhabited. 6. And a bastard shall dwell in Ashdod, and I will cut off the pride of the Philistines. 7. And I will take away his blood out of his mouth, and his abominations from between his teeth: but he that remaineth, even he, shall be for our

God, and he shall be as a governor in Judah, and Ekron as a Jebusite. 8. And I will encamp about mine house because of the army, because of him that passeth by, and because of him that returneth: and no oppressor shall pass through them any more: for now have I seen with mine eyes.

The second part of the second division of Zechariah's prophecy commences at chapter 9. This chapter consists of two parts. In the first eight verses an announcement is made to Aram (Syria), Phoenicia, and the Philistine cities that they, after having undergone grave disasters and destructions, will finally share with Israel in the true worship of Yahweh. The second part (vv. 9-17) predicts the coming of the King of Zion, Who as the Prince of Peace will command and bring about peace among all the nations.

Some commentators have denied the connection between the eighth and the ninth chapters. In our opinion, however, this connection is clear. In the last verses of chapter eight a great influx of Gentiles to Israel and Israel's God was promised. In the first eight verses of chapter nine the manner in which this will one day happen is shown. The abrupt style of these verses makes it very difficult to grasp their correct significance.

First of all, commentators are immediately faced with the word *Hadrach* (9:1) because they believe such a region is not known. But according to J. D. Michaelis and van Hamelsveld, it is a piece of land close to Damascus. This has been established by Assyrian sources.

Second, the expression "its rest" is not clear. Many interpret it as the "burden" of the Lord (cf. 9:1). In that case, the purpose is that in these regions the Word of the Lord will be revealed one day in a most horrible manner. But this reading is a bit forced. It agrees better with the preceding and succeeding verses if we translate: "Damascus will be His place of rest" (or resting place). That means Yahweh will have His seat in that city and many worshippers as well. The basis for this interpretation is indicated in the last clause, namely, that the Lord has His eyes on men, as on all the tribes of Israel. The noun "man" represents here all of humanity outside of Israel and "eye" represents His watchful care and providence. This has been correctly called a glorious utterance.

From this pronouncement, general grace among the most spiritually dark Gentiles is to be explained. The Lord of the entire earth does not limit His care to only one nation, but has in His vision included the entire human race. He is the Creator and Sustainer of all people, and one day all flesh will come to Him. Thus, in "the times of restoration of all things" (Acts 3:21) pagan Damascus will also serve Him "in spirit and truth" (cf. John 4:23). Thus, God's Word is our security, indeed. Hamath, the second largest city of Aram, will share in Damascus' privilege. There, too, Yahweh will have His seat or place of rest .

Next Phoenicia, along with its two famous cities Tyre and Sidon, is mentioned as being embraced by a God-given salvation. And yet salvation is not placed in the spotlight but judgment, because the people fancied themselves as very wise, powerful, and wealthy. They will, however, share in the promised salvation, though the Phoenicians were "very wise" (9:2). But salvation does not travel the way of judgment, sketched in three clearly drawn lines (v. 4). Tyre was a daughter-city of Sidon and gradually grew in power and wealth beyond the mother-city. Later it was situated on a small island half a mile away from the mainland and surrounded by a 150 foot high wall. It was such a strong bulwark

that it could resist Shalmaneser five years, Nebuchadnezzar ten years, and Alexander the Great seven months. The Macedonian world conqueror succeeded in capturing it by putting a dam near the mainland, in which endeavor he used the ruins of ancient Tyre which once lay on the mainland. This endeavor demanded of him an immense effort, but through it he let proud Tyre pay immensely too; he killed eight thousand people and sold thirty thousand as slaves.

Last in line are the Philistine cities. The country of the Philistines consists of five cities, each of which (with the exception of Gath) are named here (vv. 5-7). There was no other way than the news of Tyre's destruction to shake and frighten neighboring Philistia. Thus it is introduced as a trembling of fear. The cities had ample reason to fear for they were Tyre's allies. Besides, they served Dagon, a fish or sea deity, and was it not true that Alexander succeeded in capturing Tyre by means of the sea?

History annals mention, indeed, that Alexander moved from Tyre to Philistia and played havoc there. He was the instrument in God's hand to chasten Israel's centuries-old hereditary foe and to inflict the retribution of the Lord's strict justice.

And yet for Philistia, too, salvation will dawn one day. The description of judgments suddenly makes room again for the promises of salvation. The Lord promised: [He] "will take away the blood from his mouth, and the abominations from between his teeth" (v. 7). The Philistines, like the other Asiatic nations, evidently drank the blood of the sacrificial animals during their idolatrous feasts. This is also meant by the word "abomination." Here it is made known that the idolatry among the people of that nation will one day cease. This nation, the miracle of grace, will some day be devoted to the Lord as a holy remnant. It will be as a prince in Judah, and Ekron will be as the Jebusites, that is, incorporated into Israel. Here a historical allusion is made to Jebus, the stronghold of Zion, whose inhabitants, following the conquest by David, accepted Israel's faith and were incorporated into Israel (cf. 2 Sam. 24:16ff).

A difficult question remains regarding the place where we must seek the fulfillment of this prediction. If we take it as matter-of-fact, then we must say (after all the ink has been poured unto it) that there is nothing in history that will demonstrate what can be considered as fulfillment of the Word of the Lord. We confirm the word of Dachsel who writes, among other things, "Our prophecy will be fulfilled only when all empires will have been conquered." In the former land of the Philistines during the period of Israel's restoration there will still dwell people for whom all this will be fulfilled in the days of the restoration of all things.

Protection and safety are at last promised Israel (v. 8). The Lord promises His people that He will protectively camp around His temple so that the armies (of Alexander and his successors, for instance) in their march would not destroy His house and that the "oppressor" or tyrant would no more go through them.

This promise has not as yet been fulfilled, even in our own age. Though just delivered from the hand of the Turks, Jerusalem is still being trodden down by the Gentiles. *[Ed. note: Bultema wrote this before Israel's modern statehood.]* Presently the great tyrant, the antichrist, will march through Jerusalem. This prediction as well will be fulfilled in all its details at Christ's future. Then the Lord will look with His eyes again in grace on His people and His city.

The Coming of The Prince Of Peace (9:9-17)

9. Rejoice greatly, O daughter of Zion; shout, O daughter of Jerusalem: behold, thy King cometh unto thee: he is just, and having salvation; lowly, and riding upon an ass, and upon a colt the foal of an ass. 10. And I will cut off the chariot from Ephraim, and the horse from Jerusalem, and the battle bow shall be cut off: and he shall speak peace unto the heathen: and his dominion shall be from sea even to sea, and from the river even to the ends of the earth.

11. As for thee also, by the blood of thy covenant I have sent forth thy prisoners out of the pit wherein is no water. 12. Turn you to the stronghold, ye prisoners of hope: even today do I declare that I will render double unto thee; 13. when I have bent Judah for me, filled the bow with Ephraim, and raised up thy sons, O Zion, against they sons, O Greece, and made thee as the sword of a mighty man.

14. And the Lord shall be seen over them, and his arrow shall go forth as the lightning: and the Lord God shall blow the trumpet, and shall go with whirlwinds of the south. 15. The Lord of hosts shall defend them; and they shall devour, and subdue with sling stones; and they shall drink, and make a noise as through wine; and they shall be filed like bowls, and as the corners of the altar.

16. And the Lord their God shall save them in that day as the flock of his people: for they shall be as the stones of a crown, lifted up as an ensign upon his land. 17. For how great is his goodness, and how great is his beauty! corn shall make the young men cheerful, and new wine the maids.

These nine verses make mention of the coming of the Prince of Peace and the results of His "mighty acts." For the sake of brevity we merely touch on the main ideas.

(1) First of all, let us note Christ comes as a King. As Israel's King He comes to Jerusalem endowed with the following qualities (cf. v. 9): He is just, brings salvation, and is poor and lowly. The four Gospels mention that this has initially been fulfilled, but we are also told that Christ Himself weeping aloud said: "You did not want it" (Mt. 23:37; Lk. 19:41-44). He came to his own, but His own "did not receive Him" (John 1:11), so we may safely conclude this word will demand a yet further fulfillment.

(2) The fruit of His coming to Israel as King is also mentioned; He will bring to nought the chariots from the northern and the war horses from the southern empires. Even the military bow will be broken. In other words, He will break apart militarism. This will not happen without a push and a shove, for it is said significantly that He will command peace. The nations do not want peace. This appears nowadays very clearly. Hardly have the horrors of the great wars passed and nations have again become intent on making additional destructive inventions, greater armies, and mightier fleets. All treaties in the last years appeared merely as wasteful and the entire world is filled with grudges and resentment, so we may say, indeed, that the only way to establish peace on earth is through a command by a mighty personality. Now, this our Savior will do.

(3) He will be not only a mighty Prince of Peace, but also One with absolute power, for He will rule "from sea to sea and from the River to the ends of the earth" (v. 10b). In

another chapter the prophet expresses it as follows, "In that day the Lord is one, and His name one" (14:9).

(4) Israel, locked up in a ghastly prison (v. 11), will be delivered by the One through Whom their covenant of grace is established with the blood of the Prince of Peace. They are invited to return to the stronghold, that is, Jerusalem. They are prisoners, but with hope in their hearts. Is this not a striking picture of Israel, a people bound together for centuries and never without hope! We do not believe we must join some translators in translating that their hope is "in bonds." The people themselves are here addressed as being in prison and put in fetters. Israel, which has been doubly punished on account of its sins, will one day receive the double blessing of the first-born son among the nations (v. 12).

(5) Verses 13-15 show that Yahweh will make all of Israel, after their acceptance of Him, a judgment and a chastisement for their former oppressors. We should not think here exclusively of the victories of the Maccabean heroes; for though perhaps verse 13 alludes to it, verse 14 clearly points to the glorious appearance of the Christ. He will blow the war trumpet, and as lightning and a whirlwind He will attack the enemies of His people. Israel shall eat and drink of the meal of slaughter at Armageddon.

(6) Inexpressible benefices He will bring to His people, but chiefly two: a) He will be a Shepherd-prince to Israel and Israel will be His flock; and b) Israel will be like "jewels of a crown" or a decorated "banner over His land" (v. 16). When the prophet from a far distance sees this future glory of Israel, he then exclaims in rapture, "Yea, how good and how fair it shall be" (v. 17a) "How great is their goodness" (v. 17a)!

When the false prophet Balaam would one day behold the same, he would pray, "let my end be like his" (Num. 23:10b). How magnificent will be the beauty of Christ and of His restored people. The young men and the virgins will joyfully cheer while they witness all that splendor.

The Splendor Of Restored Israel (Chapter 10)

1. Ask ye of the Lord rain in the time of the latter rain; so the Lord shall make bright clouds, and give them showers of rain, to every one grass in the field. 2. For the idols have spoken vanity, and the diviners have seen a lie, and have told false dreams; they comfort in vain: therefore they went their way as a flock, they were troubled, because there was no shepherd.

3. Mine anger was kindled against the shepherds, and I punished the goats: for the Lord of hosts hath visited his flock the house of Judah, and hath made them as his goodly horse in the battle. 4. Out of him came forth the corner, out of him the nail, out of him the battle bow, out of him every oppressor together. 5. And they shall be as mighty men, which tread down their enemies in the mire of the streets in the battle: and they shall fight, because the Lord is with them, and the riders on horses shall be confounded.

6. And I will strengthen the house of Judah, and I will save the house of Joseph, and I will bring them again to place them; for I have mercy upon them: and they shall be as though I had not cast them off: for I am the Lord their God, and will hear them. 7. And they of Ephraim shall be like a mighty man, and their heart shall rejoice as through wine: yea, their children shall see it, and be glad; their heart shall rejoice in the Lord.

8. I will hiss for them, and gather them; for I have redeemed them: and they shall increase as they have increased. 9. And I will sow them among the people: and they shall remember me in far countries; and they shall live with their children, and turn again. 10. I will bring them again also out of the land of Egypt, and gather them out of Assyria; and I will bring them into the land of Gilead and Lebanon; and place shall not be found for them. 11. And he shall pass through the sea with affliction, and shall smite the waves in the sea, and all the deeps of the river shall dry up: and the pride of Assyria shall be brought down, and the sceptre of Egypt shall depart away. 12. And I will strengthen them in the Lord; and they shall walk up and down in his name, saith the Lord.

Chapter 10 is a further description of the future splendor of restored Israel begun at the nine preceding verses. The Lord reminds His people they would not acquire and maintain this glory mechanically, but in the way of prayer and through expulsion of all superstition. Has their centuries-long wandering as sheep without a shepherd not been the bitter fruit of their idolatrous vanity? Yes, Israel had enough shepherds, but these were false prophets, as Ezekiel 34 depicts in great detail.

The Lord's wrath was aroused against them and also the goatherds, that is, He visited the enormous pride of the world empires (cf. Isa.14:9; Ezek. 34:17; Dan. 8:5). At present, after centuries-long endured sufferings, the Lord is once again the good Shepherd for His flock. This beautiful image of the Shepherd and the flock is, time and time again, used by the prophets in connection with Israel's future restoration. But let us not think Judah will be a defenseless flock, for the Lord will make its people proud and strong as a war horse, equipped for battle by God Himself.

Verse 4 points to the fact that Judah would have its own independent governmental structure as well as its own army led by its own commanders. "Corner" is a place of honor in the Orient. Thus the cornerstone is the most important stone of the edifice and the corners of the tribes (Isa. 19:13) are the heads of the respective tribes. Thus, the cornerstone points to the princes, the leaders of the state. A "peg" in the wall was in Oriental homes a very significant object, for people hung on it not only clothes but also pots and pans. In this manner the peg is the image of the notable state employees on whom many depended (cf. Isa. 22:23ff.). The bow used in battle represents here, as in many other passages, the entire army, and the archer the army's commander-in-chief. In picturesque language it is being said that in the future Judah will be a completely equipped state. As heroes the Hebrews will presently trample their foe "in the mud of the streets" and they will pull to the ground even the many horsemen of their foes, because the Lord arises to fight for them (v. 5).

We can safely assume with most interpreters that these words have been fulfilled in the heroic time of the Maccabean Wars, because during the reign of the Prince of peace the

battle bow (chs. 9-10) will be broken, and there will no longer be armies in Israel ready for action. But way too far a field are those interpreters who would like to place the genuine and final fulfillment of all this in the Maccabean period. For we already know, on the basis of the important prophecy of Balaam, that in the future Israel will tear apart its former oppressors as an old lion, according to the divine law of retribution. And that is the reason this picturesque description will not fully be fulfilled until then. This appears, indeed, rather clearly enough in what follows:

(1) Both empires will be brought back and united (v. 5; cf. Isa. 11:12-26; 27:12-13; Ezek. 37). *Lo-Ruhamah* (Not-pitied) will become *Ruhamah* (Pitied), and will be as if it were never cast off.

(2) There will be an exceptionally great joy in Ephraim and its offspring (v. 7).

(3) After the Lord with His whistling gathered them together and brought them back, He grants them great fruitfulness and increase so they become a numerous people (v. 8).

(4) It is not clear whether verse 9 considers a future sowing among the nations or a past sowing. The most natural reading and interpretation is that it views a future sowing. In the reign of peace the Lord will sometimes send His people on important errands among the nations. But though they dwell in far-away places, yet they will think of Him, serve Him, and along with their offspring, return at the Lord's timing to the fertile land of Israel, designated as Gilead and Lebanon (v. 10b).

(5) Finally, verse 11 reminds us that before that great glory will dawn Israel must pass through a sea of affliction. Between Israel's present and future lies a great oppression which will be the day of "Jacob's trouble" (Jer. 30:7). But the Lord will go before them, crush all resistance, kill all Judah's enemies, and redeem His people forever from all anxiety (vv. 11-12).

The Wages of The Good Shepherd (Chapter 11)

1. Open thy doors, O Lebanon, that the fire may devour they cedars. 2. Howl, fir tree; for the cedar is fallen; because the mighty are spoiled: howl, O ye oaks of Bashan; for the forest of the vintage is come down. 3. There is a voice of the howling of the shepherds; for their glory is spoiled: a voice of the roaring of young lions; for the pride of Jordan is spoiled.

4. Thus saith the Lord my God; Feed the flock of the slaughter; 5. whose possessors slay them, and hold themselves not guilty: and they that sell them say, Blessed be the Lord; for I am rich: and their own shepherds pity them not. 6. For I will no more pity the inhabitants of the land, saith the Lord: but, lo, I will deliver the men every one into his neighbor's hand, and into the hand of his king: and they shall smite the land, and out of their hand I will not deliver them.

7. And I will feed the flock of slaughter, even you, O poor of the flock. And I took unto me two staves; the one I called Beauty, and the other I called Bands; and I fed the flock. 8. Three shepherds also I cut off in one month; and my soul loathed them, and their soul also abhorred me. 9. Then said I, I will not feed you: that that dieth, let it

die; and that that is to be cut off, let it be cut off; and let the rest eat every one the flesh of another. 10. And I took my staff, even Beauty, and cut it assunder, that I might break my covenant which I had made with all the people. 11. And it was broken in that day: and so the poor of the flock that waited upon me knew that it was the word of the Lord. 12. And I said unto them, If ye think good, give me my price; and if not, forbear. So they weighed for my price thirty pieces of silver. 13. And the Lord said unto me, Cast it unto the potter: a goodly price that I was prized at of them. And I took the thirty pieces of silver, and cast them to the potter in the house of the Lord. 14. Then I cut asunder mine other staff, even Bands, that I might break the brotherhood between Judah and Israel.

To understand correctly this and all other prophecies we must keep clearly in mind that fulfilled and unfulfilled predictions are intertwined and as a rule the prophets without any obvious transition combine the first coming of Christ with His future appearance to Israel. Commentators often correctly compare this with a mountain landscape where the far-away mountain peaks are seen immediately behind the more closeby, without perceiving there is a deep and wide valley with a number of smaller mountains in between. This phenomenon we can also observe frequently with our prophet. Thus, the largest part of this chapter points to the first coming of Christ. The first three verses of chapter 11 are a continuation of what preceded. In the previous chapter it was promised that Israel would be brought back and restored in its own land. But Israel had entered Canaan already twice before and both times it had to wrestle fiercely with enemies who dwelt in Canaan. Now the question was called as to how this would happen in the future return to the land of the fathers. To that question the first three verses give an answer. The Lord Himself will open the northern gates for them, and the proud cedars of Lebanon will be burnt through the fire of His judgment. To have a right view of these verses we must know that the proud nations and rulers are compared with the trees of the forest. The prophets make this comparison more than once (cf. Isa. 2:13; 10:3334). Even in verse 3 the downfall of the princes and leaders of the people is written in a beautiful and poetic way.

Verses 4-14 describe symbolically the casting off of the Jewish nation on account of its rejection of the Messiah. Thus, the prophet suddenly turns his gaze from the glory of the future to the enormous drama which must precede that glory according to the "determinate counsel and foreknowledge of God" (cf. Acts 2:23). The exegetes, who do not wish to link this good shepherd with Christ, obscure the meaning of this chapter through all kinds of twisted interpretations. The prophet must, however, first show the people the good shepherd and then the evil shepherd through a symbolic and typical act. While the latter is not explicit, it is often the nature of a symbolic act that it only contains a lesson for the people if it is being viewed by them.

Well, there was a flock of sheep which the prophet as a shepherd has to tend. But what a flock! It did not consist of sheep which were tended for their wool, milk, and lambs, but of sheep to be slaughtered, sheep which were fatted for the day of slaughter. The owners of these sheep are pictured as cruel tyrants and hypocrites (v. 5). They do not aim at the well-being of the sheep as a faithful shepherd always does, but they become rich at the expense of the sheep. Here we have, indeed, a striking picture of the Jewish

national leaders in the days of Jesus. The Lord predicts He will bring about a civil war and a total destruction concerning such wicked conduct (v. 6).

The prophet, portraying the good Shepherd in His humiliation, pitied the sad situation of these sheep and will therefore tend the wretched sheep. Through love and unanimity He still wishes to save the flock. Through another symbolic act, the staffs of "Beauty" and "Bands" (v. 7), this is represented in a very picturesque manner. Here it is not difficult for those who believe the Scriptures to recognize the two main features of the Savior's ministry. Just as a hen gathers together her chicks in love, in the same way He wants to gather the "chicks" of His people.

"In one month I destroyed the three shepherds," says the Lord (v. 8). Who are these three shepherds? Much has been written about it by interpreters. A common but not very acceptable explanation is that they refer to three parties of the people in Jesus' days: the Pharisees, the Sadducees, and the Herodians. It is best to think of three kinds of Israelite shepherds: prophets, priests, and kings. For these have been cut off in one month, that is, in a very short time, through Christ's rejection and judgment.

In spite of all the love and care shown by the good Shepherd to the flock, the result was that both collided and then separated. The Lord became sad concerning the wandering sheep and left His flock alone, saying: "Let what is dying die" (v. 9a). Who does not think again of the saying of the Savior: "You will no longer see me from now on" (Mt. 23:39), and "may your house remain desolate" (Mt. 23:38). How striking it is in a short passage, this drawing of the aversion of the Jews to our Savior; "and their soul also abhorred me" (v. 8b).

When the good Shepherd let go of His flock the results were dreadful. Significant are the words: "Let those that are left eat each other's flesh" (v. 9b). Have internal discord and civil wars been more clearly described than in this short sentence? The Lord abandoned them to punishment and selfdestruction. As a sign thereof the prophet broke the staff "Beauty" (v.10). The Lord withdrew his special love relationship with Israel and therewith also broke the covenant which He had made "with all the peoples."

This expression, too, is very difficult to understand. Many a commentator uses it as a proof text that God has now broken the covenant of grace with Israel and has then transferred it to the Church; Scripture, however, teaches us in many passages that on the Lord's side the covenant of grace cannot be broken. To cite one well-known Psalm, "[God's] judgments are in all the earth. He has remembered His covenant forever. The word which He commanded, for a thousand generations" (Ps. 105:7-8). We must here think of His covenant with the nations outside of Israel's borders, of which in early Hebrew history Jacob had spoken on his deathbed, "to him shall be the obedience of the people" (Gen. 49:1Ob). And the nations would never have led Israel into slavery, would never have dominated its people had Israel lived a life of obedience to Yahweh. The fact that this staff had been broken into two pieces was as it were a signal to the nations that for many centuries they could hold Israel in subservience.

That the pious from among Israel, those converted to God, saw in it all the hand of the Lord and the fulfillment of His Word is mentioned in verse 11. For a long time they had hoped it was He who "was going to redeem Israel" (Luke 24:21) and that" He would

restore Israel's kingdom" (Acts 1:6); but later they acquiesced in the Lord's Word and way as the justifiable punishment for Israel's rejection of the Messiah.

From Matthew 27:9-10 it is clear we must explain verses 12-13 as a prophecy concerning Judah's betrayal and selling of its Master for thirty silver coins, the price of a slave (Exod. 21:21). The critical commentators have pointed out the difference in words and representation between the real facts of the case of the matter and this prediction. Here the Shepherd Himself asks for His wages. But they are deemed to be of too little value and at God's command are thrown away ignominiously, whereas in history the betrayer himself obtained his wages and later in desperation threw them before the feet of the priests. This difference can be explained in that the prophet views and describes the issue from the Lord's side and the Gospel from Judas' side. The resemblance is sufficiently striking though: the Messiah is deemed worthy the price of a slave for all His love shown to Israel, and these wages are thrown down in the house of the Lord for the potter, in order, as we later learn, to purchase the "potter's field" (Mt. 27:7). After the Lord had ordered our prophet to throw away indignantly thirty pieces of silver he broke the second staff, "Bands," as a sign all unity in Israel would from now on be broken (v. 14).

The Evil Shepherd (11:15-17)

15. And the Lord said unto me, Take unto thee yet the instruments of a foolish shepherd. 16. For, lo, I will raise up a shepherd in the land, which shall not visit those that be cut off, neither shall seek the young one, nor heal that that is broken, nor feed that that standeth still: but he shall eat the flesh of the fat, and tear their claws in pieces. 17. Woe to the idle shepherd that leaveth the flock! the sword shall be upon his arm, and upon his right eye: his arm shall be clean dried up, and his right eye shall be utterly darkened.

Verses 15-17 narrate how the prophet must now enact symbolically the role of an evil shepherd. He had to take the implements of a "foolish" or worthless shepherd (v. 15), including a staff, a bag, and a sling. This symbolic act will be performed before the very eyes of the people and is to register that through rejecting the good shepherd Israel would fall into the hands of an evil shepherd and thereby become extremely anxious. It is clear this is meant as the complete opposite of the good shepherd.

Verse 16 describes rather exhaustively this evil shepherd; he will neglect, destroy, and tear apart the flock. The awful curse of the Lord is pronounced over him (v. 17). The puny shepherd is no representation of the Roman Empire, nor of the Jewish zealots, but of the antichrist, who in every respect will be a complete antipode of our Lord Jesus Christ. Some day the "man of sin" (2 Thess. 2:3) will be not only a Jew but also the most severe oppressor of the Jews ever in existence. In our grave times the image of this evil shepherd begins to show itself on the horizon more and more.

Israel's Splendor (12:1-9)

1. The burden of the word of the Lord for Israel, saith the Lord, which stretcheth forth the heavens, and layeth the foundation of the earth, and formeth the spirit of man within him. 2. Behold, I will make Jerusalem a cup of trembling unto all the people round about, when they shall be in the siege both against Judah and against Jerusalem. 3. And in that day will I make Jerusalem a burdensome stone for all people: all that burden themselves with it shall be cut in pieces, though all the people of the earth be gathered together against it. 4. In that day, saith the Lord, I will smite every horse with astonishment, and his rider with madness: and I will open mine eyes upon the house of Judah, and will smite every horse of the people with blindness. 5. And the governors of Judah shall say in their heart, The inhabitants of Jerusalem shall be my strength in the Lord of hosts their God.

6. In that day will I make the governors of Judah like a hearth of fire among the wood, and like a torch of fire in a sheaf; and they shall devour all the people round about, on the right hand and on the left: and Jerusalem shall be inhabited again in her own place, even in Jerusalem.

7. The Lord also shall save the tents of Judah first, that the glory of the house of David and the glory of the inhabitants of Jerusalem do not magnify themselves against Judah. 8. In that day shall the Lord defend the inhabitants of Jerusalem; and he that is feeble among them at that day shall be as David; and the house of David shall be as God, as the angel of the Lord before them. 9. And it shall come to pass in that day, that I will seek to destroy all the nations that come against Jerusalem.

Chapter 12 consists of two parts, though their content is very closely connected. Verses 1-9 point once again to the glory and luster of the Jewish nation beyond all nations. According to verse l, Israel is the object of this "burden" of the Lord. Scribes writing comments in the margins wrote: "Understand here for Israel the Christian Church or the Congregation, consisting of Jews and Gentiles." But this goes counter to the inscription of this divine pronouncement. The prophet knew not the congregation as the Body of Christ, consisting of Jews and Gentiles. He speaks concerning Israel and the nations. He emphatically says to us here that Israel is meant, preventing commentators from thinking only of Judah and Jerusalem and thereby excluding the northern tribes.

Another question is to which time this prophecy pertains? Many older interpreters make it to bear on the history of the church, but no more is the church meant here than the history of the church is written here. Concerning church history, let us not seek it in the ancient prophets, for they always connected the future glory with the sufferings of Christ. What was in between these two happenings, the congregation as the mystical body of the rejected Messiah, was hidden from their view, as we are emphatically told in the New Testament.

Neither can we explain these verses as related to the period of the Maccabees. The somewhat rationalistic interpreter Van Hamelsveld is more on target than many orthodox interpreters when he says: "There is very much reason that it is probable that these last three chapters of Zechariah belong to the final centuries, in which we expect

a complete restoration of all things." It is true that much of this main division can be related to the time of the Maccabees. Not everything, however, for the future of David's dynasty (cf. v. 8), for instance, does not in the least point to the history of the Maccabees.

This third part, consisting of the last three chapters, has a clear period of time in view, which is mentioned over and over again. The words "in that day" occur no fewer than fifteen times. The events here narrated will take place on the great Day of the Lord, concerning which the prophets spoke so often. It is the day in which the world powers will be judged, the battle of Armageddon will be waged, and Israel will be delivered from all its anxieties and placed ahead of the nations. We should take these words in the closest connection with the preceding, where the fury and the fall of the antichrist is mentioned. One ought to compare these last three chapters with Ezekiel 38-39, where the prophet refers to the deliverance of Israel at the time when Gog and Magog besiege Jerusalem.

The first thing predicted of Jerusalem is that it will be placed by the Lord as a "cup of trembling" or reeling (12:2) to the nations. The picture of a cup of reeling or "drunkenness" is frequently employed by the prophets (cf. Jer. 48:26; Nah. 3:11; etc.). The point of this picture is that as the instrument of God's wrath Jerusalem will cause the nations to stagger and fall down as a drunken person.

The second image used by the prophet is that of a "burdensome" or heavy stone (v. 3). This is an allusion to a very ancient custom, according to which heavy stones were placed in certain locations in cities and villages to let the young men test and try their powers. Should they have too heavy or too sharp a stone, then that was a "burdensome" stone. With this brief explanation we can easily enough understand this image. The nations which gather against Jerusalem will badly bruise themselves on this stone.

A third representation is of the cavalry. According to the Mosaic law, Israel was not allowed to possess a cavalry or chariots. The condition of Canaan's soil did not lend itself to it either. Israel's enemies are represented as horsemen, who as such would have a decided advantage over Israel. Therefore the Lord promises He would strike their horses with confusion and their horsemen with insanity and perplexity ("madness"); but in contrast, He will look upon Judah with favor.

In those days Judah's leaders will make a beautiful confession, saying in their heart, "the inhabitants of Jerusalem shall be my strength in the Lord of hosts their God"' (v. 5b). The meaning of this difficult verse is apparently to point indirectly to the glory of Jerusalem. The strength of the city of God is in its God and is of such appeal that the rulers of the people in Judah rely on and seek its support.

Verse 6 presents another picturesque representation of the just-mentioned rulers of Judah. In that time, they will be like a firepan in the woodpile or a fiery torch in the woodpile. These images, as is further explained, point to a consuming blaze, to which everything must yield. The nations, flocking together with their immense armies, will then be consumed by the Jews, their King being their leader. We refer once again to Ezekiel 38-39 where this enormous warfare is extensively sketched in its origin, scope, and consequences.

In former days it was not at all uncommon in Jerusalem that refined city-dwellers looked down in conceit upon boorish country people. Is this not, indeed, the case even today? Alluding to this historical fact, the prophet says the Lord will grant a blessing to Judah's country people (v. 7). The Lord is no respecter of persons; no matter how glorious the house of David and Jerusalem may be, there will never be the least reason for the city of the great King to lift itself above the people of the country. Indirectly, but nevertheless powerfully, this verse points as well to Jerusalem's future glory. The Lord Himself will protect Jerusalem in that day through His own presence and will make the feeblest like David (v. 8), and the dynasty or house of David shall be like "God," indeed, like the "Angel of the Lord," leading them to battle as their head (v. 8). David's illustrious scion, Christ, will personally be present.

The Great Mourning (12:10-14)

10. And I will pour upon the house of David, and upon the inhabitants of Jerusalem, the spirit of grace and of supplications: and they shall look upon me whom they have pierced, and they shall mourn for him, as one mourneth for his only son, and shall be in bitterness for him, as one that is in bitterness for his firstborn. 11. In that day shall there be a great mourning in Jerusalem, as the mourning of Hadadrimmon in the valley of Megiddon. 12. And the land shall mourn, every family apart; the family of the house of David apart, and their wives apart; the family of the house of Nathan apart, and their wives apart; 13. the family of the house of Levi apart, and their wives apart; the family of Shimei apart, and their wives apart; 14. all the families that remain, every family apart, and their wives apart.

Two texts shed light on this remarkable passage: John 19:37 and Revelation 1:7. These verses, compared with this passage, show us that after their return to Jerusalem and after their being poured over with the Holy Spirit Who causes them to beg for grace and forgiveness, Israel will recognize its sovereign King. At one time they pierced Him - an atrocity! Should someone object that a Roman soldier committed this act, then that must be conceded; but this was charged to Israel's account, for the Jews had delivered Him to Rome! "They shall look upon me whom they have pierced". What a sight that would be for Israel! Let us thoroughly represent the matter.

Israel had returned to the land and Jerusalem had been rebuilt and the people had lived peacefully and happily for some time. But on a certain day there came suddenly many nations who "covered the land as a cloud." The leader of this predatory expedition is Gog, the principal prince of Rosh, Russia. Israel is drawn into the greatest possible oppression and anxiety, but when the need reaches its culmination point, then Christ shows Himself on the clouds of heaven along with His glorious congregation. On that day people will mourn over Him, as Israel had never mourned before.

That event is pointed to in three comparisons: the people will mourn over Him as over an only child (v. 10); they will weep bitterly over Him as over a first-born son. Both these comparisons are to be understood from the viewpoint of deepest sadness and most

genuine repentance. The third comparison, a historical one, reveals that the people will mourn over Him as over a much-loved king, as the people once did regarding pious king Josiah. The place Hadadrimmon can nowhere be located on the map of Canaan. It must have been a very tiny village in the valley of Megiddo, famous as the spot where excelling Josiah was killed in the battle with Pharaoh Necho (cf. 2 Kgs. 23:29; 2 Chr. 35:20-25).

This mourning will be not only very deep but also very general. The entire land, every family, will participate in it. Some scornfully asked whether people can be so gullible as to believe the Jews in that day would still know their genealogical registers. But such an assumption is wholly superfluous. Here it probably refers in general to the royal, prophetic, and priestly and Levitical families. David as a typical representative of the kingly, Nathan of the prophetic, Levi of the priestly, and Shimei of the Levitical "family".

That every "family," also the women, are said to mourn separately supposedly points to the customs displayed at feasts of mourning and funeral ceremonies. With such prophetic strokes we must not lose track of the fact that the prophets always choose their starting-point in their contemporary circumstances. Thus, it is very well possible that in order to sketch the magnitude of future mourning, Zechariah named by name simply the most important families in his area dwelling in Jerusalem. At the Lord's time, in any case, this mournful cry will be heard in Palestine.

The Opened Fountain (Chapter 13)

1. In that day there shall be a fountain opened to the house of David and to the inhabitants of Jerusalem for sin and for uncleanness.

2. And it shall come to pass in that day, saith the Lord of hosts, that I will cut off the names of the idols out of the land, and they shall no more be remembered: and also I will cause the prophets and the unclean spirit to pass out of the land. 3. And it shall come to pass, that when any shall yet prophesy, then his father and his mother that begat him shall say unto him, Thou shalt not live; for thou speakest lies in the name of the Lord: and his father and his mother that begat him shall thrust him through when he prophesieth. 4. And it shall come to pass in that day, that the prophets shall be ashamed every one of his vision, when he hath prophesied; neither shall they wear a rough garment to deceive: 5. but he shall say, I am no prophet, I am a husbandman; for man taught me to keep cattle from my youth. 6. And one shall say unto him, What are these wounds in thine hands? Then he shall answer, Those with which I was wounded in the house of my friends.

7. Awake, O sword, against my shepherd, and against the man that is my fellow, saith the Lord of hosts: smite the shepherd, and the sheep shall be scattered: and I will turn mine hand upon the little ones. 8. And it shall come to pass, that in all the land, saith the Lord, two parts therein shall be cut off and die; but the third shall be left therein. 9. And I will bring the third part through the fire, and will refine them as silver is refined, and will try them as gold is tried: they shall call on my name, and I will hear them: I will say, It is my people; and they shall say, The Lord is my God.

This short chapter likewise consists of two parts. In verses 1-6 (part one) the prophet dramatically sketches how restored Israel is cleansed from all sin and uncleanness (13:1). As a result, Israel will show an ardent zeal for the name of the Lord. In verses 7-9 (part two) the violent death of the good shepherd is mentioned and as its result, the scattering and elimination of two-thirds of the flock.

This chapter is very closely related to chapter twelve. The scene of the great mourning described there will be the full realization of the great Day of Atonement. "On that day," the Lord had said, "you shall afflict yourselves" (Lev. 16:29). As Israel's atonement was measured in greatness, so the mourning will be great; but the atonement remains while mourning passes by. In the millennial reign of peace there will no longer be room for the great Day of Atonement, but there will be the Passover as the festival of remembrance, and the festival of Tabernacles as the feast of joy (cf. ch. 14 below; Ezek. 45:2125).

We mentioned already that chapter thirteen is connected with the preceding chapter. Said more clearly, we have here a striking contrast between acts of mourning there and expressions of joy here. For in the Scriptures an "opened," that is, an ebullient fountain or spring is the symbol for being joyous (cf. Ps. 87:7; Isa. 12:3). We can explain that on the basis of Palestine's scarcity of water. Israel will experience what the separate individual believers encounter in their lives; the Holy Spirit, who first convicted them of sin and guilt and brought about penance and repentance, will presently initiate the joy of salvation.

To the question of when and where this fountain will be opened, most commentators answer: on Golgotha. We wholeheartedly agree. The cause for the forgiveness of all guilt and all cleansing can be located only on Golgotha in Christ's atoning suffering and death. But we cannot possibly concur that here is given a representation of the suffering and death on Golgotha. To the question of "when," verse 2 contains the answer: "on that day," a phrase present no fewer than six times in chapter twelve, seven times in chapter fourteen, and three times in our short chapter. This phrase, used by the other prophets and ours, points again and again to the great Day of the Lord on which Christ will come to judge the powers of the world, render Satan harmless, cause Israel to return from all the lands, convert them, and place them ahead of all the nations.

After Israel's heart-felt conversion, the year of jubilee of all years of jubilee, the great year of the Lord's pleasure, commences and is pictured here as well. Then Israel will receive the fulfillment of what centuries ago was chanted prophetically: "with joy you will draw water from the wells of salvation" (Isa. 12:3). Blessed then is the entire nation, because the Deliverer came from Zion in order to remove godlessness from Jacob, to forgive its transgressions, and to cover its sins.

Should one ask how this fountain of salvation is opened, then the answer must be: through the suffering and dying of our precious Savior. From his bleeding side originates all present salvation for the congregation and all that lies in the future for Israel and the nations. How large in size, how rich in significance and scope does the death of the lamb of God become in this manner! As a Dutch hymn has it: "Jesus, your atoning death is the point of rest for our heart and thinking, for our glance of faith backward and for our gaze of hope forward." The heavens shall praise your dear atoning blood forever, and Israel and the nations will do this on earth as well, for during

the millennial reign of peace this fountain continually bubbles up its purifying waters over Israel and the nations. Just as Hagar did not see the well of water in the wilderness (cf. Gen. 21:15ff.), in the same way Israel at present does not see at all that this fountain has been opened for the congregation.

After Israel's cleansing, its civic acts were to be cleansed too, as described by the following verses. The Lord will "cut off' the names of the idols (v. 2), so these will no more be remembered. The false prophets, who in the preceding centuries caused Israel much untold misery, will likewise no more exist.

And thirdly, the Lord will also purge the unclean spirits from the realm of the demons. Here the passage refers to fortune-telling, augury, and magic. The unclean spirits from the realm of the devil were active not only in questioning the dead, the spiritism of that period, but also in the false prophets as is clear from 1 Kings 22:21ff.

It is not superfluous to ask here whether there will be true prophets during the millennial reign. It seems to us we may reply rather negatively. Prophecy and the prophets shine as a light in the darkness. Should the darkness no longer cover the earth and the peoples, and should the bands of the face of all the nations have been removed (Isa. 25), then in such a glorious state of affairs there is no ¯need for the light of prophecy. There is something else. Then the heavens are opened, and the Lord dwells in the midst of His people. And, at last, we can add that only in Israel the tall and the small will know the Lord and have no need anymore to be taught. It will be a people of prophets, and the prophecy of Joel will then be fully realized; Israel's sons and daughters will prophesy and the old men will dream dreams and the young men will see visions (Joel 2:28). Therefore even Moses' prayer, "Would God that all the Lord's people were prophets" (Num. 11:29) will be fulfilled. And when there are only prophets, there is no longer a need for the particular office of prophet. With Eiselen it seems to us Zechariah thinks of the removal of the prophetic office in general.

Yet it is clear from what follows that he aims his view especially toward the removal of the false prophets. And therein are comprised all the false prophets of our age, for what is said here concerning the promised land and Israel applies simultaneously to all the earth and all the nations. At present the world is full of false prophets, who, as real demagogues, are succeeding to line the stupid masses behind them and subtract from the simplicity of Christ's gospel. The great Prophet warned seriously against it, and our puny prophet predicted the end of all of these. The true prophets have been greatly burdened by false prophets, and therefore we need not be surprised that the "soul" of our true prophet is filled with the joyful news of a future fact: the elimination of the false prophets. Let us cast a cursory look at that event.

In order to imprint deeply on the soul of his people the complete destruction of the false prophets, he unfolds before them a domestic scene. It seems he remembers what the Mosaic law prescribed concerning the false prophets; the next of kin were to kill them (Deut. 13:5-10). A dramatic domestic scene is painted. There are a father and a mother who have a son of their own whom they as right-minded parents love. On a certain day they come to know he spoke falsely in the name of the Lord. They are aglow with such a zeal for the name of Yahweh that their parental love, as it were, is swallowed up by it and they will "thrust him through" in holy wrath (v. 3).

It goes without saying that Zechariah does not wish to express with this scene that after Israel's restoration there will still be many false prophets. Rather, he wishes to express three things: 1) then the prophets will no longer be able to "blossom" as before; 2) the law of retribution (*lex talionis*) will be in full force and the Mosaic law maintained; and 3) the love and zeal for the name of the Lord will swallow up every other expression of love and Israel will be a very holy people.

Next, the prophet sketches the fall of the false prophets in still another way when he says the prophets will be ashamed on that day to show their faces in public. Beforehand, day after day the false prophets enjoyed great esteem among the people and in the royal palaces, but on the day of the future this will be entirely different. Even if there would be a person here and there, who in the inner part of his heart was a false prophet, he would not dare to broadcast that, for then sinners would no more rule on earth as they do now, but would feign their submission. Imitating Elijah, the false prophets in former days wore a hairy mantle (2 Kgs. 1:18; Mt. 7:15) in order to become to the people an extraordinary savor of holiness, but then they will no longer dare or be able to do so. Much rather will they disguise themselves than to be known as prophets (v. 4).

Should someone still be about to suspect he was a prophet, then he would repudiate this accusation with indignation, saying: "I am no prophet, I am a tiller of the soil" (v. 5) - from his early youth, he would add. He much rather resorts to a lie and assigns himself to the lowest social class than confess to be involved in the vanities of the false prophets (v. 5). Yet this lie, uttered in dire need, does not convince; therefore there arose a lively dialogue with the false prophet. The false prophets attempted more than once, in a typically Gentile manner, to wound themselves in their "rage" (1 Kgs. 18:28; Deut. 14:1; Jer. 16:6). Alluding to this custom, he is asked: "What are these wounds in your hands?" (v. 6). Again he lies when he replies: they are "those with which I was wounded in the house of my friends" (v. 6b). There are interpreters who explain this as a remnant of parental chastisements; others of incisions made in the behalf of idols, whom the people frequently named their lovers or mistresses (Hos. 2:7, 10). The Hebrew word for wound points to fresh wounds, so that the first explanation is good-for-nothing. Perhaps he says this only to divert suspicion from and to arouse sympathy for himself.

At any rate, there is an explanation (v. 6) which we must not endorse, namely, the Messianic one which interprets this verse in the light of the suffering Savior. In this and the following verses there are mainly three different views. First, many interpreters start with verse 6 and explain everything in the light of Christ; they point to the fact He, too, was whipped in the house of His beloved ones. Second, there are those who interpret each of these verses as pertaining to the false prophets. And third, there are many interpreters who bring v. 6 to bear on the false prophets and verse 7 on the Christ. The last view is the only sound explanation.

People might possibly wonder that suddenly the prophet mentions once again the suffering and dying of Christ, but to that objection we can reply that this is a permanent prophetic feature. Therewith we have a striking contrast between the false prophets, who one day will be embodied in the false prophet of the last days, and the Messiah-the true Prophet. At last, the remark of those making marginal notations is to the point when

they record: "Whereas in the preceding verse it is said how the false prophet is treated by his own friends, the Lord uses the occasion to predict how Christ, His beloved Son and supreme Shepherd, would be whipped and killed as if He were a false prophet." Yet that would not happen by chance but according to His divine ordinance. That verse 7 pertains to Christ, all orthodox interpreters agree. Even the more or less rationalistically inclined van der Palm writes: "We must renounce every explanation and application of this passage, unless we interpret it as related to a violent death, which the Messiah-the great Shepherd of His nation-underwent through divine arrangement; that is the reason Jesus applies it to Himself" (cf. Mt. 26:31; Mark 14:27).

This last is a conclusive proof that this verse refers to the great Shepherd, Who gave His life for His sheep. In this word, however, no reference is made to His voluntary sacrifice nor to His rejection by Israel as in 11:12. But here it is positively viewed from the point of view of His Father, who, according to His determined counsel linked all our unrighteousness to Him and to Whom it pleased Him to "shatter" His beloved Son. Israel rejected and pierced its Messiah, it is true, but according to the "determined counsel" of the Lord (Acts 2:23).

Thus the sword of righteousness seeking vengeance is called upon here from the side of the Father against His own Son. The sword symbolizes every murderous weapon wielded against Christ. In contrast to the false shepherd or perhaps the false prophet, He is here called "my shepherd." He is further called "my companion." Used of humans this designation means "comrade," "partner," or "equal." This is a powerful Old Testament proof for the deity of the Deliverer, for He is named here the "equal" of the Lord of hosts.

The direct consequence of the slaying of the Shepherd is that the sheep will be scattered. Without a shepherd, a sheep is the most defenseless animal. A horse has its hoofs, an ox its horns, a dog its teeth, a porcupine its quills; a sheep, however, has not power nor weapon, and also no courage, and in addition is extremely prone to wander. Hence the sheep are such a striking picture for the believers. In themselves they are nothing. All their might rests with the good Shepherd; apart from Him they walk straight into the mouth of wolves, fall into ravines, and roam in the wilderness. For, should the sheep have abandoned the shepherd, they would not remain together. Strikingly this appears when Jesus was captured (Mt. 26:31), and in Israel's own history (cf. Isa. 53:6).

But the Lord promises He would turn His hand "against the little ones" (v. 7b). God's hand is powerful and lofty, protecting the pious; it is, further, a gentle, caring, and faithful hand. The "little ones" mean first of all the disciples, who from among Israel believed in Him, and, further, every one who has become a little child for Him may apply this to himself, for the great Shepherd of the sheep "was brought again from the dead" (Heb. 13:20).

Without a noticeable transition, the prophet speaks further about the partial destruction of the sheep, such as will take place on the Day of the Lord or at the beginning of the reign of peace. Two thirds of the people will perish, but one third shall be left alive according to the election of grace (v. 8). But before the full glory of the reign of peace will commence, even that one third must be "refined" as silver is refined, just as gold is purified in a smelting furnace. In the great oppression they will call upon the Lord, and

the Lord will hear their prayer; at His return Christ will name them "my people," and they will reply, "'The Lord is my God'" (v. 9; cf. Isa. 25:8-9). The beginning of the next chapter will tell us how the remnant will at last be refined.

Jerusalem's Capture And Deliverance (14:1-4)

1. Behold, the day of the Lord cometh, and thy spoil shall be divided in the midst of thee. 2. For I will gather all nations against Jerusalem to battle; and the city shall be taken, and the houses rifled, and the women ravished; and half of the city shall go forth into captivity, and the residue of the people shall not be cut off from the city. 3. Then shall the Lord go forth, and fight against those nations, as when he fought in the day of battle. 4. And his feet shall stand in that day upon the mount of Olives, which is before Jerusalem on the east, and the mount of Olives shall cleave in the midst thereof toward the east and toward the west, and there shall be a very great valley; and half of the mountain shall remove toward the north, and half of it toward the south.

The entire final chapter points to the future. Neither the days of the Maccabees nor the destruction of Jerusalem by Titus nor even the history of the Christian church show us anything resembling a fulfillment of this remarkable prophecy. The time of the literal fulfillment will come on the great Day of the Lord, which one could fittingly call the time of the founding of the millennial reign of peace; the time in which "Not my people" will again become "My people" (cf. Isa. 29:3-6; Joel 3; Ezek. 38-39).

The Lord first of all points to a dark picture. Jerusalem's treasures will be distributed by the enemy who had penetrated the city. Verse 2 extensively refers once more to the final taking of Jerusalem. Headed by Russia, all the nations will then gather for battle against Jerusalem where the initially restored but not as yet converted people dwell. These nations are inspired by a satanic spirit. The capture of the city is a very light task for them, for the city is inhabited as a village. The enemy plunders the houses, dishonors the women, and deports half of the captured citizens to a cruel slavery. One part of the inhabitants, however, maintains control over a section of the city (v. 2). Then the anxiety will have reached its peak, so that those left behind, anxious as they were, begin to call upon Yahweh for help. And as was said in the last verse of the preceding chapter, the Lord will hear this prayer. When the need is the highest, the Lord will grant Israel complete relief, albeit in an unexpected manner.

Verse 3 tells us how the Lord will accomplish this. He will "go forth," that is, He will march on from His glorious heaven in order to rescue the anxious stronghold of His people and crush all their enemies. He will fight on behalf of Israel and be victorious, just as He was beforehand.

To the question as to how He will come, the answer must be, as a war hero. This is the way He is pictured for us in Revelation 19. He will come under the most awful and frightful natural events such as earthquakes, thunder, and lightning. And if we ask from where He comes, the answer is, from the Mount of Olives (v. 4). From this mountain He has taken off and to the same spot He will return, as can be derived from the word of the angels (Acts 1:11-12). He will come crowded round by all His sanctified people (v.

5). These are not the angels, though even these will be a part of His shining entourage. We must here think of His most glorious congregation taken up in the sky before the Great Tribulation and having celebrated with Him earlier the supper of the wedding of the Lamb (cf. Rev. 19; see also 1 Thess. 3:13; 4:17; 2 Thess. 1:7-8; Jude 14-15; Tit. 2:13). Let us take a closer look at the glorious consequences of His return.

The Fruit of Christ's Return (14:5-11)

5. And ye shall flee to the valley of the mountains; for the valley of the mountains shall reach unto Azal: yea, ye shall flee, like as ye fled from before the earthquake in the days of Uzziah king of Judah: and the Lord my God shall come, and all the saints with thee.

6. And it shall come to pass in that day, that the light shall not be clear, nor dark: 7. but it shall be one day which shall be known to the Lord, not day, nor night: but it shall come to pass, that at evening time it shall be light.

8. And it shall be in that day, that living waters shall go out from Jerusalem; half of them toward the former sea, and half of them toward the hinder sea: in summer and in winter shall it be.

9. And the Lord shall be King over all the earth: in that day shall there be one Lord, and his name one.

10. All the land shall be turned as a plain from Geba to Rimmon south of Jersualem: and it shall be lifted up, and inhabited in her place, from Benjamin's gate unto the place of the first gate, unto the corner gate, and from the tower of Hananeel unto the king's winepresses. 11. And men shall dwell in it, and there shall be no more utter destruction; but Jerusalem shall be safely inhabited.

When we speak of the fruit of the Savior's return we have in mind only the fruit of His coming back as described here, for even the devils and the animals will experience the consequences of this coming, but the text does not address itself to that subject unless indirectly and intrinsically.

In the first place, Jerusalem will be freed when He appears. What no earthly army had been able to accomplish He alone will bring about. Earlier, Isaiah had penned this very beautifully in the following words: "As a lion roars, and a young lion over his prey (When a multitude of shepherds is summoned against him, He will not be afraid of their voice nor be disturbed by their noise), so the Lord of hosts will come down to fight for Mount Zion and for its hill" (Isa. 31:4). Mindful that "no prophecy of Scripture is of any private interpretation" (2 Pet. 1:21 a), we earnestly recommend this great subject to all investigators of Scripture. Compare this text mainly with the following texts: Daniel 11:44-45; Joel 3:2; Isaiah 66:16; Ezekie138-39; Revelation 16:16; 19:19-21.

In the second place, the greatest possible changes will take place at the return of Christ with His own. All things "consist in Him," says the apostle (Col. 1:17b). Thus, it need not surprise us at His return in majesty and glory as the Son of Man that everything is lifted from its fastening, or stated more properly, all things are put back again in their own

ranks. Through sin everything is taken away from its nitch but at His future time He will erect again all things. When His feet touch the Mount of Olives the mountain is split into two, causing a very wide valley through which the remnant will be able to escape from their pursuers. The rocky mountain will be removed and all of Palestine will become another paradise, a leveled plain (v. 10). Jerusalem alone will be lifted up in order to magnify its religious splendor and prestige as the city of the great King. These changes on the ground, as well as the great fertility and flourishing of all of Canaan, were promised one time to the patriarchs but never realized until now, not even in the days of Solomon. All this explains to us how one day such a mighty people will dwell in the promised land.

In the third place, the most gigantic natural phenomena will take place, especially among the planetary systems, to which verse 6 aims. Though Christ Himself comes like lightning and makes the clouds the dust of His feet, it will nevertheless be a day of thick darkness. The sun will be darkened, the moon will not give light, the stars will fall from heaven, and the powers of the heavens will be shaken when in the sky appears the sign of the Son of Man (Mt. 24:29).

But when the stone rolling down the mountain destroys the great image representing the world and has crushed all the kingdoms together (cf. Dan. 2:35f.), then the light will be a marvelous light. In the evening of the day of the Great Tribulation there will be light (v. 7).

In the fourth place, after the oppressor has been smashed and the righteous have received retribution for their oppression, Christ will commence His reign of righteousness as the King of the entire earth. He is the King of the Jews. As such He is announced of old, born, worshipped, confessed, applauded, and then put to death. As Ezekiel wrote, "My servant David shall be their prince forever" (Ezek. 37:25b). But that does not alter the fact that the entire earth will be subject to Him (cf. Ps. 8; 47:7; 72:8; 89:25; 98:6; Rev. 11:15). Under His supreme command the princes will rule the nations in righteousness (Isa. 32:1). Of these princes, those of Judah will be first (Ezek. 44).

In the fifth place, then there will no longer be the many religions as there are now, but only one world-wide religion. This is announced in the following words: "On that day the Lord will be one and his name one" (v. 9b). What a comfort for everyone in the confusion of our era, but most comforting in the area of religion, that our Lord Jesus on His future timetable will establish one religion across the whole earth. This is misunderstood by all the present-day federation movements. These movements will come to nothing except as the great horrible Babylon, the great harlot (Rev. 17-18).

Oh, that patience had a complete effect among Christians. Then people would wait for Him Who in His own time will make everything all right. And may all who believe the Scriptures as the infallible Word of God not be slow and unwise to believe all that the prophets predicted! Jerusalem, further, will be the center of blessing for the whole world. This is indicated to us by the phrase "living waters" (v. 8) or life-giving waters, which flow from Jerusalem. The same salvific event is mentioned in Ezekie147 and Joel 3:18. It will be a stream of salvation which will neither be made dry by the heat of the summer sun nor congeal through the cold of winter. The one half flows toward the Dead Sea and the other half to the Mediterranean Sea. It seems we must take these designations in a

geographical sense, but there is nothing that prevents us from taking them symbolically at the same time .

Finally, it is said people can once again dwell safely in Jerusalem. No curse, no captivity, no disaster or calamity of any kind will ever strike the residence of the great King and the capital of the entire world. Under His protection and care its inhabitants will deem themselves safe. Then Isaiah 33:16 will be fulfilled.

What a glory here on earth the word of prophecy mentions. This earth has become a valley of tears and sadness on account of sin. Thorns and thistles, wild animals, and wild human beings can be spotted on the earth's surface. On earth we also encounter countless generations waiting for the illustrious day of the future. Above the earth in the sky we see innumerable hosts of evil spirits; but the legitimate Ruler of this earth is rejected by His own people who, therefore, are scattered across all nations. The world empires rule over Israel and corrupt the earth (Rev. 17-18), and the entire creation groans and longs for the day of revelation of the children of God.

God be praised that there is also someone waiting in the highest heaven. Christ is waiting in His glory till "His enemies are made His footstool" (Heb. 10:13). Therefore, we can always be of good courage in the midst of the storms of time, for if we wait in the darkness of the night we know that beyond the darkness there is One Who is waiting and Who at the Father's time will reestablish all things.

The Plagues Against Israel's Enemies (14:12-15)

12. And this shall be the plague wherewith the Lord will smite all the people that have fought against Jerusalem; There flesh shall consume away while they stand upon their feet, and their eyes shall consume away in their holes, and their tongue shall consume away in their mouth. 13. And it shall come to pass in that day, that a great tumult from the Lord shall be among them; and they shall lay hold every one on the hand of his neighbor, and his hand shall rise up against the hand of his neighbor. 14. And Judah also shall fight at Jerusalem; and the wealth of all the heathen round about shall be gathered together, gold, and silver, and apparel, in great abundance. 15. And so shall be the plague of the horse, of the mule, of the camel, and of the ass, and of all the beasts that shall be in these tents, as this plague.

Verses 12-15 describe the plagues on the enemies of Jerusalem. Some interpreters identify them as imaginary enemies who in the future (for instance at the close of the millennial reign of peace) will begin to expose Jerusalem to another siege (Rev. 20). But it is more appropriate to understand the enemies as those concerning whom the first two verses speak.

A plague is a special kind of pestilence. A three-fold punishment is stated here. One day the flesh of everyone will suddenly "dissolve," their eyes will "dissolve" in their sockets, and every one's tongue will "dissolve" in their mouths (14:12). There continuously appear new kinds of diseases and plagues among plants, animals, and human beings

thus it need not surprise us that the Lord in those unusual times produces a peculiar kind of pestilence in order to strike His enemies suddenly.

A "great panic" will be a second punishment (v. 13a). Through this there will be great turmoil and confusion in the ranks of the enemy, and in that noise everyone will "raise his hand against his neighbor's hand" (v. 13b). In Israel's history, the Lord often guided, on, a smaller scale, the armies of the enemies to destroy each other (2 Chr. 20:23; Judg. 7:22; 1 Sam. 14:20), and so without a battle Israel was delivered.

Finally, even Judah will make battle with the enemies. When the Lord arises to do battle He will also gird His people and Judah will acquire all the treasures of these nations (v.14). Concerning "the plague," verse 15 states it will not merely be among the people but also among all the animals of the armies of the enemy.

The Remnant of The Nations (14:16-21)

16. And it shall come to pass, that every one that is left of all the nations which came against Jerusalem, shall even go up from year to year to worship the King, the Lord of hosts, and to keep the feast of tabernacles. 17. And it shall be, that whoso will not come up of all the families of the earth unto Jerusalem to worship the King, the Lord of hosts, even upon them shall be no rain. 18. And if the family of Egypt go not up, and come not, that have no rain; there shall be the plague, wherewith the Lord will smite the heathen that come not up to keep the feat of tabernacles. 19. This shall be the punishment of Egypt, and the punishment of all nations that come not up to keep the feast of tabernacles.

20. In that day shall there be upon the bells of the horses, Holiness Unto The Lord; and the pots in the Lord's house shall be like the bowls before the altar. 21. Yea, every pot in Jerusalem and in Judea shall be holiness unto the Lord of hosts: and all they that sacrifice shall come and take of them, and seethe therein: and in that day there shall be no more the Canaanite in the house of the Lord of hosts.

Scripture does not only speak concerning the remnant of Israel, but also of the nations. We saw above that the eye of the Lord is on the nations outside of Israel (9:1). Once more He aims to have here on earth a converted world, so that He will be praised from the ends of the earth. The basic theme of all patriarchs, psalmists, and prophets ("all that has breath praise the Lord") will everywhere be applied. Therefore, He does not destroy all the inhabitants of the earth in the Great Tribulation and universal judgment. Though countless millions may die away, many millions remain alive, especially among the Gentile nations. These are from among the nations and thus a remnant. Even the prophets mention this frequently.

Of these nations it is said they will annually march to Jerusalem in order to worship the King and celebrate the Feast of Tabernacles. A voluntary marching to adore the Lord Jesus is also mentioned elsewhere (Isa. 2:1-4; 66:23; Micah 4:1-4). Thus, the Feast of Tabernacles will still be celebrated in the millennial reign. Who knows whether the complete glory of this feast will then be understood! Many a person mocks such a

thought but there is nothing unworthy of God in it; no more so our celebration in this dispensation of baptism and the Lord's Supper. *[Ed. note - Bultema did not see at this point in his studies the "one baptism" of this present Pauline dispensation as he certainly did in his later studies.]*

We know from many prophetic passages that the nations will be heartily ready to bring their tribute and treasures to Christ, but as sin will not wholly have vanished there remains the possibility here and there tribes will not march on a certain year. But they will not do it a second time, for, behold, as punishment they will not have any rain. As a result, there is utter barrenness and untold suffering for man and beast. In Egypt there is no rain as a rule; therefore, this nation is mentioned separately. Nevertheless, the Lord will know how to strike them in their disobedience just as precisely as He did the other recalcitrant nations. In case of disobedience they will perhaps not have a fertile overflowing of the Nile (vv. 1819).

The two last verses of this beautiful prophecy point, at last, to the general sanctification of all civil life of restored Israel. On the shining harness of the horses will be written "Holiness to the Lord" (v. 29a); this is the same as the engraving on the golden plate of the high-priestly "crown" (Exod. 39:30). The pots in which one cooks the sacrificial flesh, or perhaps the pots in which people gathered the ashes of the sacrifices, whichever, the most common temple utensils will be like those esteemed most holy. Yes, all the pots in every home will be equally holy and dedicated to the Lord as the so holy-valued temple utensils. In every tent and on everyone's lips the joyful singing of the righteous will be the frequent praise of the Lord. Then no Canaanite, no impure nor covetous person will enter the temple as before. We can also conceive of this last thought in the sense that the House of the Lord will no longer have an outer court but, as a house of prayer for all the nations, will be open for every one. There are no longer Gentiles in this reign of peace. The second thought is the more preferred one.

We have seen in the visions and the divine oracles of the prophet how at last the Lord Himself makes "Not my people," His "My people," a people who in the devotion of all their powers is holy and consecrated to Him.